

Append HMI Studio

User Manual

Designing, testing and deploying HMI applications,
illustrated with the LiquidWeighHMI example

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Append Automation

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1 Introduction

Append HMI Studio designs operator screens (HMIs) for PLCs, runs them against live equipment and publishes them for the plant floor. This manual shows how to build an HMI application with it, step by step, using a complete, working example: **LiquidWeighHMI**, the operator interface of a liquid weigh-up system that meters three plasticizers into a weigh hopper and discharges each batch to a mixer.

The example is included with Append HMI Studio as `examples/LiquidWeighHMI.ahmi`. Open it with **File > Open** and follow along; every screenshot in this manual was taken from it, the run-mode ones with the application connected to its ControlLogix controller.

Table 1. What the LiquidWeighHMI example contains

Part	In the example
Target screen	1920 × 1080, full screen
PLC	One ControlLogix controller (EtherNet/IP), 419 I/O tags
Screens	Process, Batch, Supply, Devices, Setpoints, Recipes, Alarm History and IO Sim
Popup windows	One faceplate for all 11 valves and 3 pumps, through indirect tags, and 4 confirmation dialogs
Alarms	34 alarmed tags, an Active Alarms list on every screen and an Alarm History screen
Security	Three users (Operator, Maintenance, Engineer) with access levels
Recipes	A recipe book of plasticizer blends with five starting recipes, and a Recipes screen to select, edit, save and download them
Scripts	Window scripts that turn the sequence step number into text, and action scripts that call the login, recipe, indirect tag, ShowWindow and ScreenToPDF functions

1.1 How an HMI application is organized

An Append HMI Studio project (`.ahmi` file) holds everything the operator station needs:

- **Devices**: the PLCs the application talks to (Allen-Bradley Logix, SLC 500 and MicroLogix, Modbus TCP, or the built-in simulator).
- **Tags**: named values, either read from and written to a PLC (I/O tags) or kept by the HMI itself (memory tags). Tags carry engineering units, ranges and alarm limits.
- **Windows**: each page of the drawing is a window of the application, either a full screen or a popup such as a faceplate.
- **Objects and animation links**: the shapes on the screens, and the links that tie them to tags: colors that follow a state, levels that fill, values that display, buttons that write.
- **Application settings**: the target screen resolution, the windows that open at start-up, how the published application runs, and its users.

The usual order of work, which this manual follows, is: application settings, devices, tags, screens and windows, animation, alarms and security, then testing with Run and deploying.

2 The Studio window

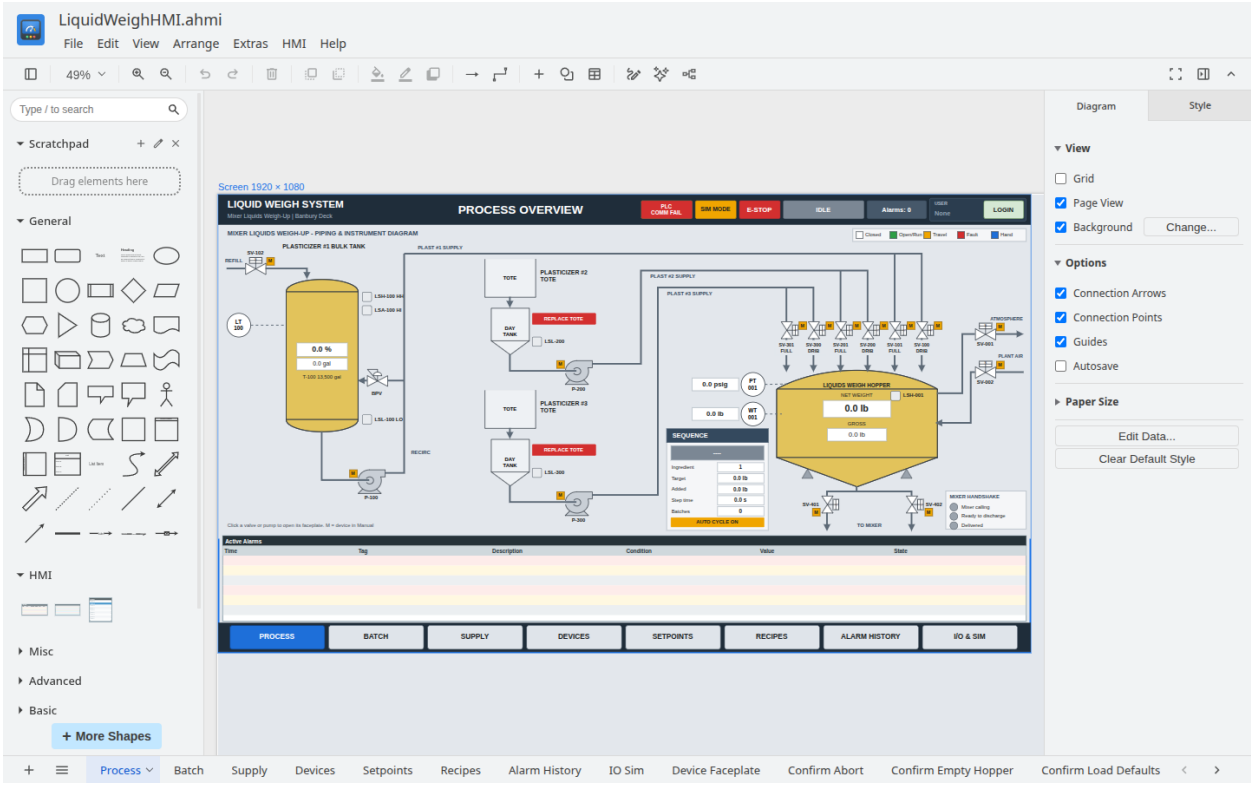


Figure 1. Append HMI Studio with the LiquidWeighHMI Process screen open

Table 2. Parts of the Studio window

Area	What it is for
Menu bar	File, Edit, View, Arrange and Extras from the drawing editor, plus the HMI menu for everything specific to HMI applications
Toolbar	Zoom, undo, delete, arrange, and quick access to fill, line and shadow
Shapes	Shape libraries (General, Misc, Advanced and more under More Shapes, including the P&ID libraries) and the HMI palette with the Alarm List and Alarm History objects
Canvas	The page being edited. The dashed Screen frame shows the target screen (1920 × 1080 here)
Format panel	Style, Text and Arrange for the selected object, and the Animation tab for its links
Page tabs	One tab per window of the application; + adds one

2.1 The HMI menu

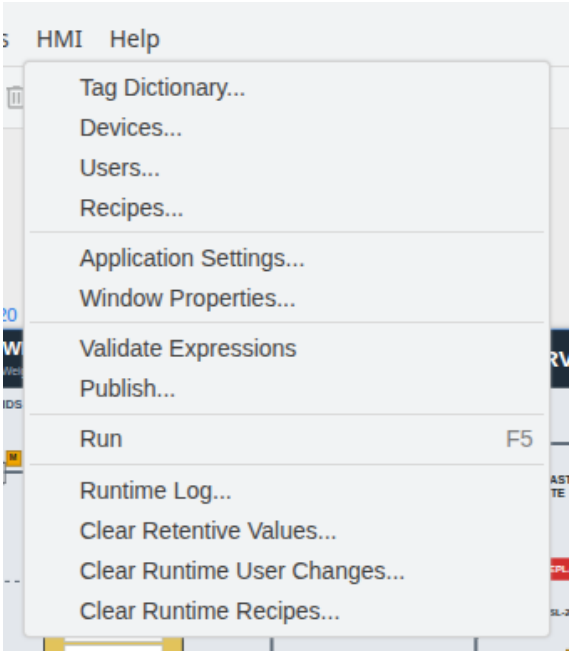


Figure 2. The HMI menu

Table 3. HMI menu commands

Command	Use
Tag Dictionary…	Create and edit tags (chapter 5)
Devices…	Configure the PLCs (chapter 4)
Users…	Users, passwords and access levels (chapter 10)
Recipes…	Recipe books: the tags a recipe holds and the starting recipes (chapter 11)
Application Settings…	Target screen, start-up windows, runtime and security settings (chapter 3)
Window Properties…	Type, position, size and scripts of the current window (chapter 6)
Validate Expressions	Check every link, script and address for errors (chapter 12)
Publish…	Build a Windows installer of the application (chapter 13)
Run / Stop (F5)	Run the application in the Studio against live or simulated data (chapter 12)
Runtime Log…	Messages from the last runs: connections, writes, script errors
Clear Retentive Values…	Forget the saved values of retentive tags on this computer
Clear Runtime User Changes…	Forget user changes made while running on this computer
Clear Runtime Recipes…	Forget the recipes saved while running on this computer

3 Application settings

Start a new application by setting its target screen: the resolution of the operator station it will run on. Open **HMI > Application Settings**.

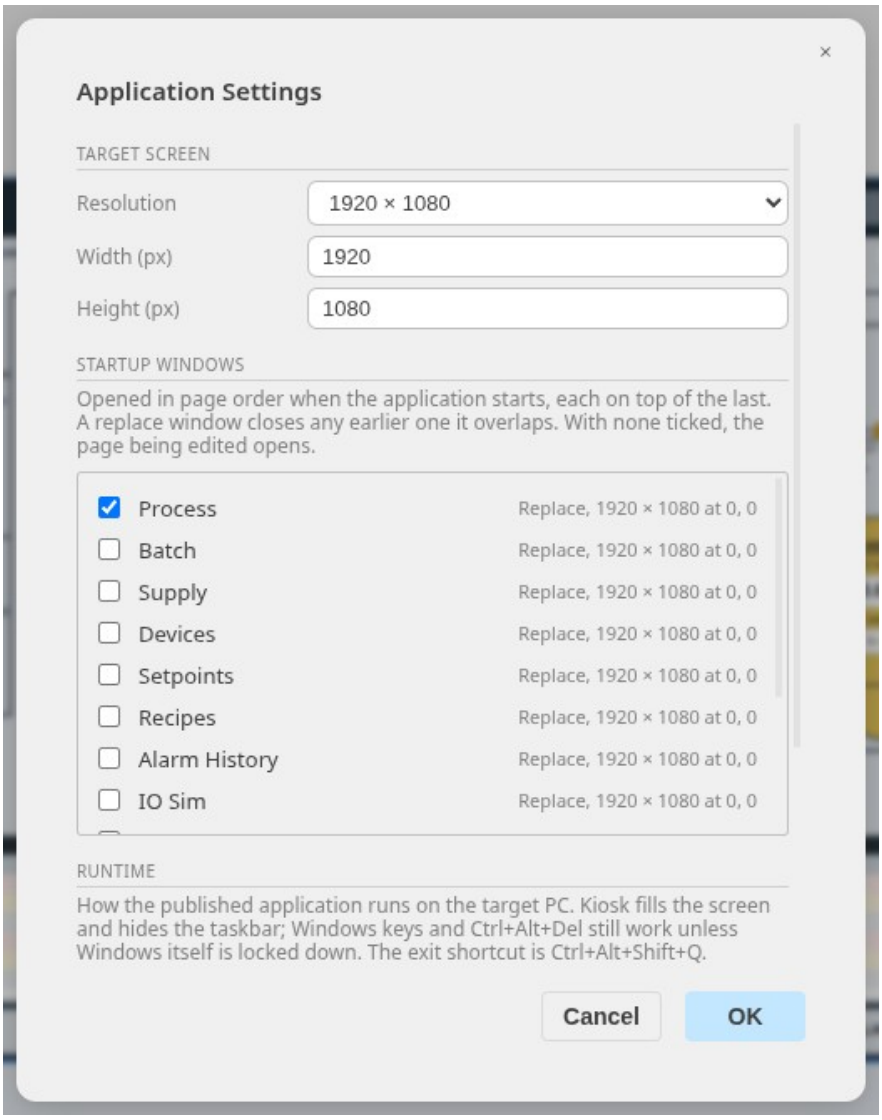


Figure 3. Application Settings: target screen and start-up windows

- **Resolution**: choose a common size or type the width and height. LiquidWeighHMI targets a 1920 × 1080 panel PC. The dashed Screen frame on every page follows this size.
- **Startup windows**: the windows that open when the application starts, in page order. LiquidWeighHMI opens the Process screen. With none ticked, the page being edited opens.

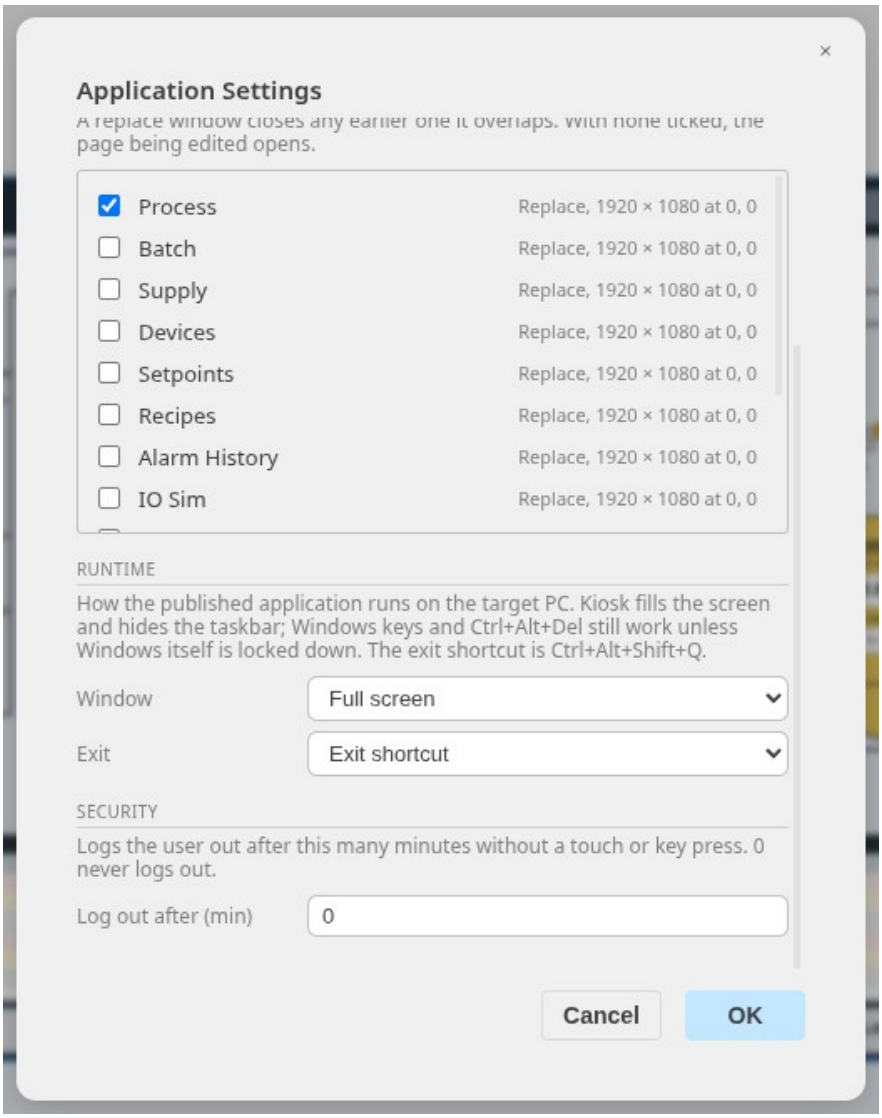


Figure 4. Application Settings: runtime and security

- **Window**: how a published application runs on the target PC: **Kiosk** (full screen, locked, taskbar hidden), **Full screen**, or a **window** at the target resolution. LiquidWeighHMI uses Full screen.
- **Exit**: the exit shortcut Ctrl+Alt+Shift+Q; the shortcut followed by a password; or never (the PC must be shut down to stop it).
- **Log out after (min)**: logs the operator out after this many minutes without a touch or key press. 0 never logs out.

4 Devices

Devices are the PLCs the application communicates with. Open **HMI > Devices**, click **Add**, and fill in the connection. LiquidWeighHMI has one device, **LiquidWeighPLC**, a ControlLogix controller.

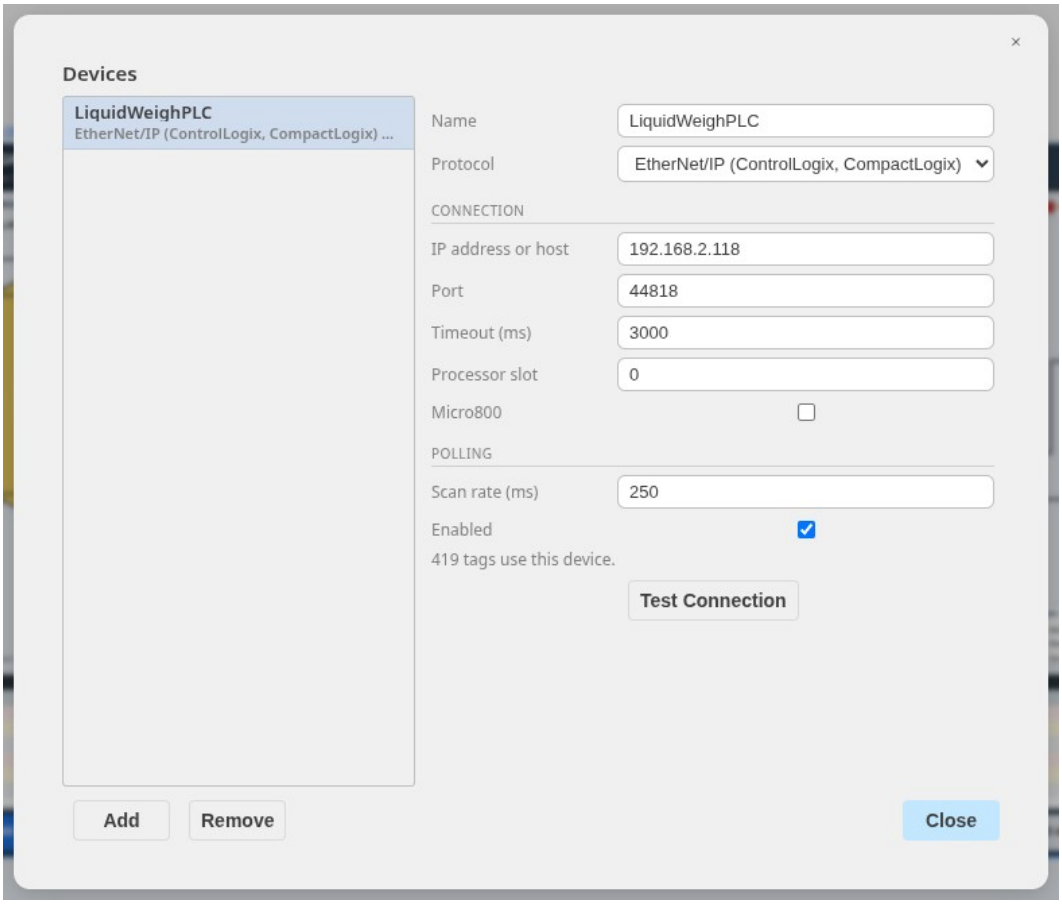


Figure 5. The Devices dialog with the LiquidWeighPLC controller

- **Protocol**: the communication driver (Table 4).
- **IP address or host**, **Port** (44818 for EtherNet/IP, 502 for Modbus TCP) and **Timeout**.
- **Processor slot**: the controller's slot in the chassis (0 for a CompactLogix).
- **Scan rate**: how often subscribed tags are read, 250 ms here.
- **Test Connection** checks that the PLC answers before any screen is built.

Table 4. Protocols and address examples

Protocol	Controllers	Address examples
EtherNet/IP (Logix)	ControlLogix, CompactLogix, Micro800	PT_001.Value Program:Main.Pump.Run Recipe[3] Status.5

Protocol	Controllers	Address examples
PCCC (SLC)	SLC 5/05, MicroLogix	N7:0 B3:1/4 F8:2 T4:0.ACC
Modbus TCP	Any Modbus TCP device	HR:0 HR:10:FLOAT CO:5 IR:3
Simulator	None (built in)	Simulated values for testing

Note: Communication runs through a small companion program, the hmi-comms server, which the Studio starts by itself. Device states and errors appear in HMI > Runtime Log.

5 Tags

Tags are the named values the screens show and change. Open **HMI > Tag Dictionary**. The list on the left shows every tag with its type; type in **Filter** to find one. Select a tag to edit it, or choose a type under **New tag...** to create one.

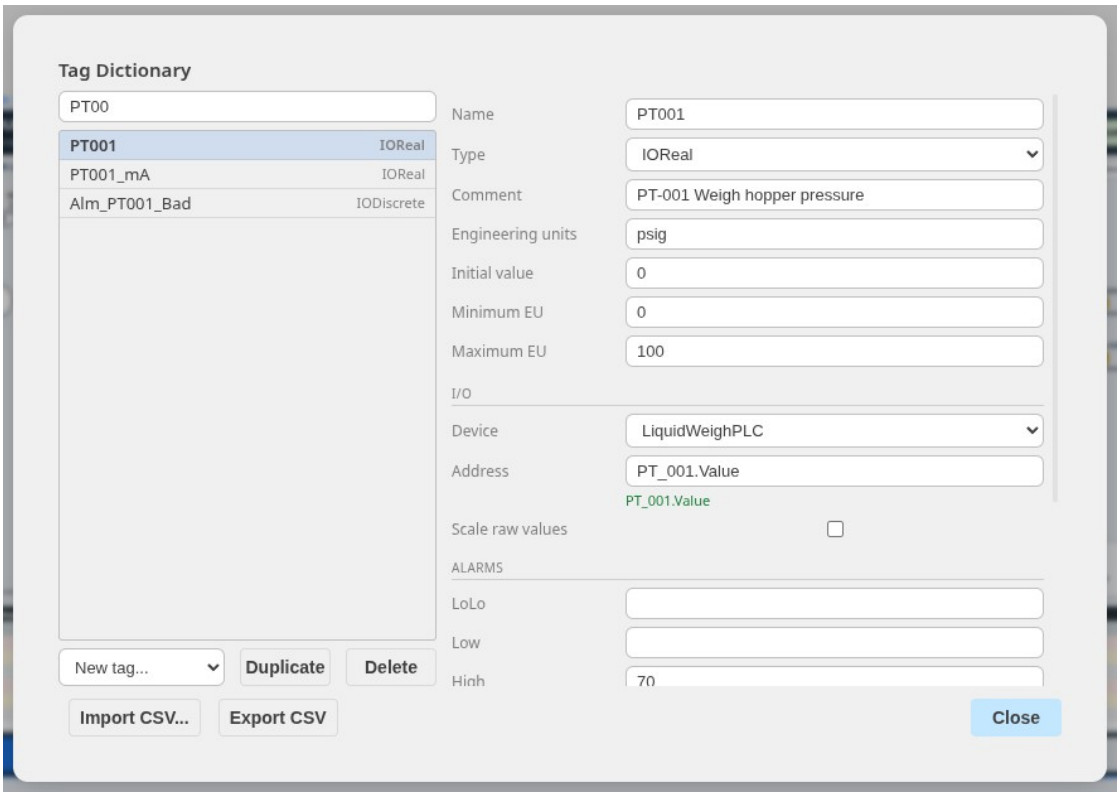


Figure 6. The Tag Dictionary with PT001, the weigh hopper pressure

Table 5. Tag types

Type	Holds	LiquidWeighHMI example
IODiscrete	On/off from a PLC	SV001_Opened (valve open limit)
IOInteger	Whole number from a PLC	SV001_Status (0 closed, 1 open, 2 travel, 3 fault)
IOReal	Real number from a PLC	PT001 (hopper pressure, psig)
IOMessage	Text from a PLC	Recipe or product names
MemoryDiscrete, MemoryInteger, MemoryReal, MemoryMessage	A value kept by the HMI	StepText (sequence step description)
IndirectDiscrete, IndirectAnalog, IndirectMessage	No value of its own: stands for the tag a script links it to with LinkIndirectTag	FP_Status: the status of the device the faceplate shows

5.1 Tag fields

Table 6. Tag fields

Field	Meaning
Name	Letters, digits and underscores; not case-sensitive. LiquidWeighHMI names tags after the device and signal, such as SV001_Status and PT001
Comment	A description. For an alarmed tag it is the alarm text operators see
Engineering units, Minimum EU, Maximum EU	Units and range, used by fills, bars and value displays
Initial value	Starting value of a memory tag
Device, Address	For an I/O tag: the PLC and the address in its syntax. The address is checked as you type (green when valid)
Scale raw values	Maps a raw integer range (for example 0 to 4095) to the engineering range
Retentive	For a memory tag: keeps its last value between runs
Simulation	A simulated value (sine, ramp, random, toggle) for testing without the PLC

5.2 Alarms on a tag

Scroll down to **Alarms** to give a tag alarm limits. PT001 alarms at High 70 psig and HiHi 85 psig, with a deadband of 2 so the alarm clears only below 68 psig. A discrete tag instead has **Alarm when** On or Off: SV001_Fault alarms when it is on.

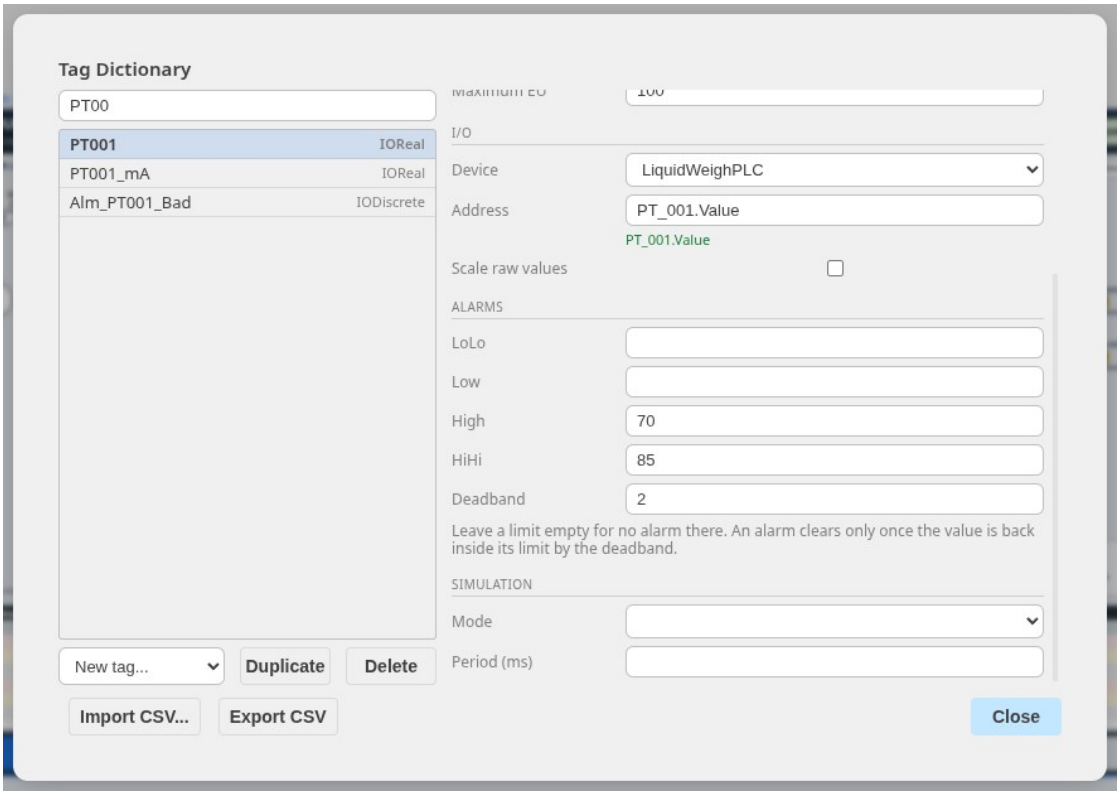


Figure 7. Alarm limits and deadband for PT001

Tags can also be exported to and imported from CSV (**Export CSV**, **Import CSV…**), which is the fastest way to create hundreds of tags from a PLC tag list: LiquidWeighHMI's 420 tags were entered that way.

6 Screens and windows

Each page of the drawing is a window of the application, named by its page tab. LiquidWeighHMI has seven full screens and eighteen popups.

Figure 8. Page tabs: every page is a window

Table 7. Window types

Type	Behavior	Used in LiquidWeighHMI for
Replace	Closes any window it overlaps when it opens	The seven main screens
Overlay	Opens on top and leaves other windows open	Information panels
Popup (modal)	Stays on top; nothing beneath it can be touched until it closes	Faceplates and confirmations

6.1 Window properties

Select a page and open **HMI > Window Properties**. The Device Faceplate is a popup with a title bar, 460 × 560 pixels at 730, 150 on the screen. The preview shows where it appears.

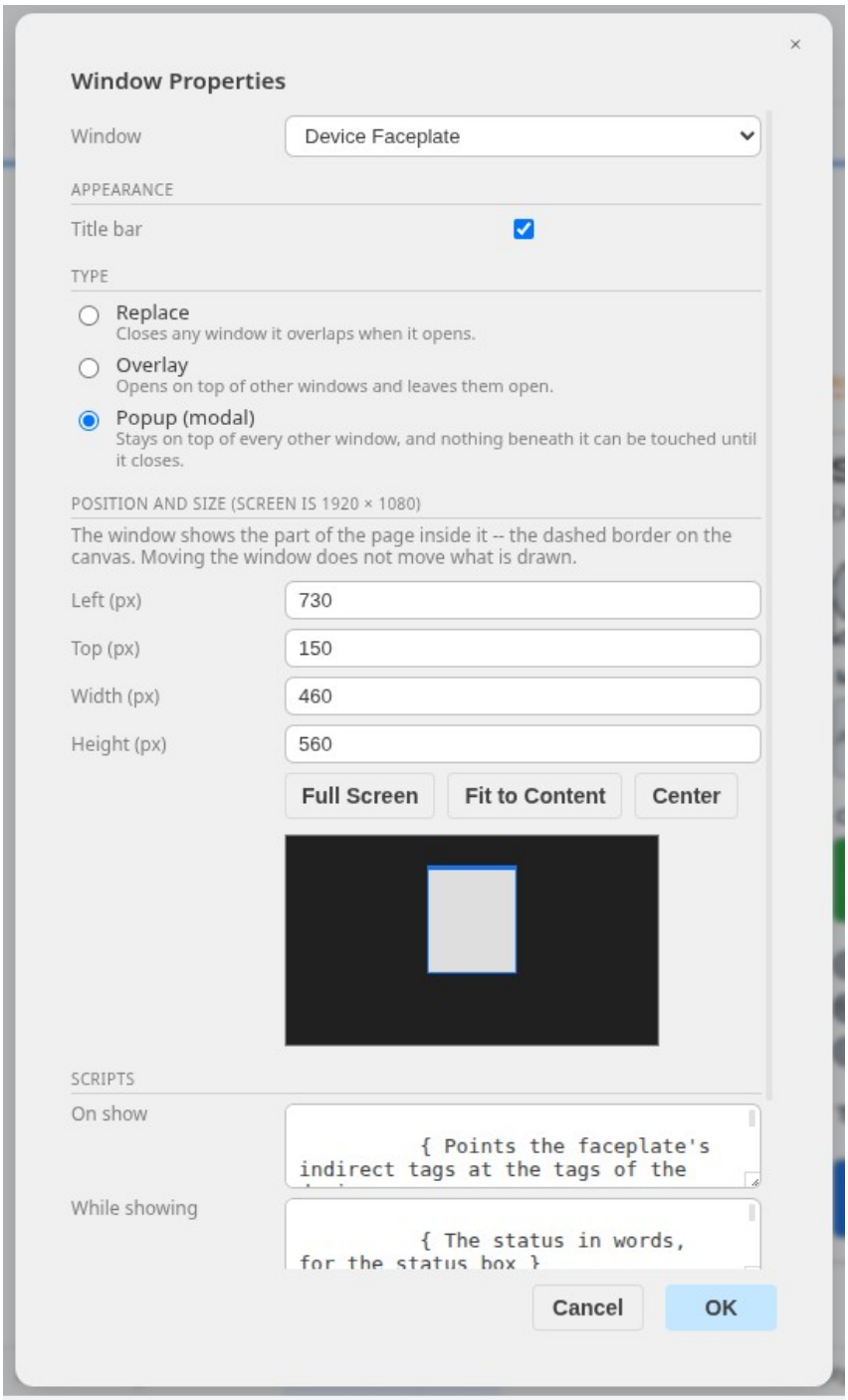


Figure 9. Window Properties of the Device Faceplate popup

A window shows the part of its page under its rectangle, so a popup's objects are drawn at the popup's position on its page. Figure 10 shows the Device Faceplate page in the editor. It serves every valve and pump (section 9.4), so a few objects for valves and for pumps share a place; visibility links show the right one while running.

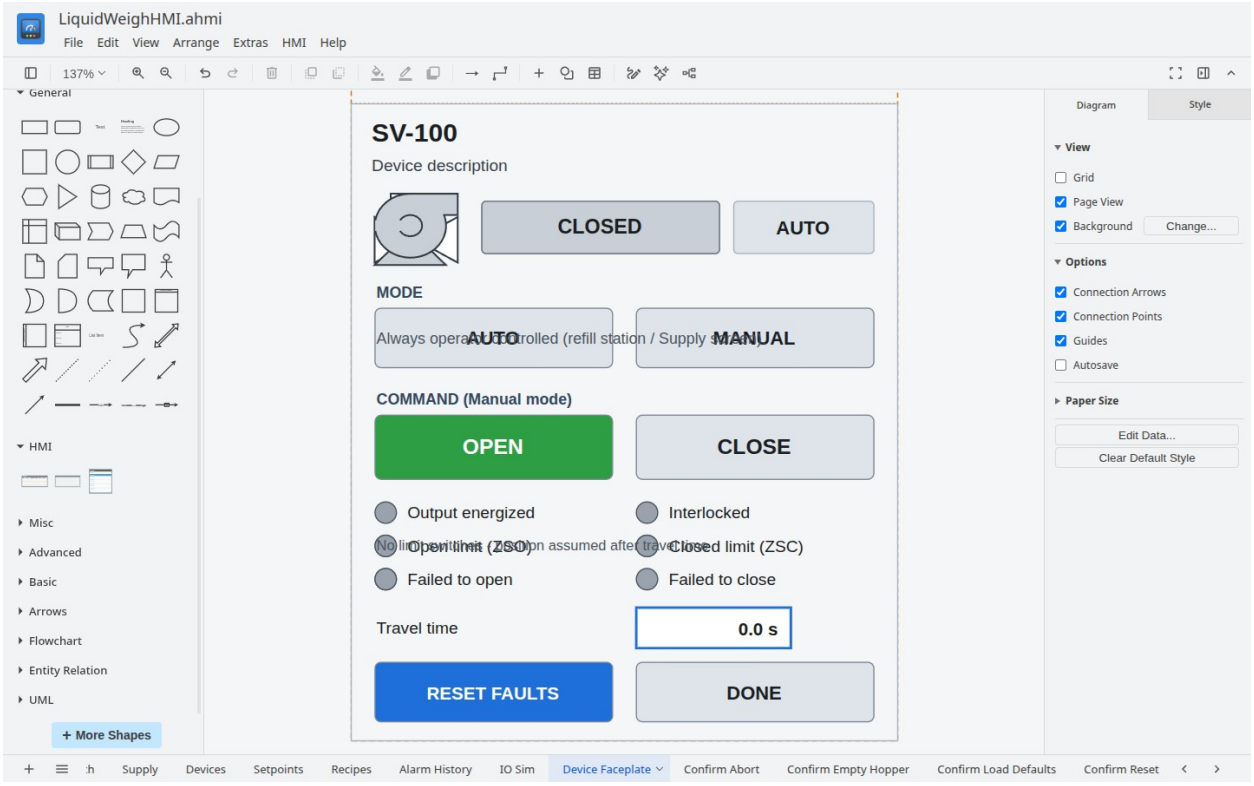


Figure 10. The Device Faceplate page in the editor

6.2 Navigation

The navigation bar at the bottom of every LiquidWeighHMI screen is a row of buttons, each with a **Show Window** link to one screen. Because the main screens are Replace windows, opening one closes the current screen. The valve and pump symbols open the Device Faceplate from their Action Scripts instead, with the `ShowWindow` function, beside the symbol touched (section 9.5); its DONE button closes it with a **Hide Window** link.

7 Drawing objects

Screens are drawn with the editor's shapes: drag a shape from the Shapes panel onto the canvas, then set its fill, line and text in the Format panel. LiquidWeighHMI uses:

- Rectangles and rounded rectangles for panels, buttons and value boxes.
- Process symbols from **More Shapes > P&ID** (valves, pumps, vessels) and plain shapes for tanks and totes.
- Lines and connectors for piping.
- Text for labels and titles.

The **General** palette ends with two **arcs**: an open curve along a circle, **Arc (Circle)**, which stays round when resized, and one along an ellipse, **Arc (Ellipse)**, which fills its box. Like lines, arcs take an arrow or other end at either end, and their width can change from one end to the other. Select an arc and open the Style tab to set it:

Table 8. Arc settings (Style tab, Arc section)

Setting	Meaning
Start angle, End angle	Where the arc begins and ends, in degrees measured as on a protractor: 0 at the right, increasing counterclockwise, so 90 is the top. The arc runs counterclockwise from the start angle to the end angle: 0 to 180 is the top half, and a start greater than the end, such as 315 to 225, sweeps through 0
Start line width, End line width	The thickness of the line at each end; it changes evenly between them. The start width is the Line width of the Line section. A line whose widths differ is drawn solid, not dashed
Start arrow, End arrow	The end at each end: none, classic, block, open, oval, diamond, box and others, as on lines
Start size, End size	The size of each end
Start filled, End filled	Whether a closed end, such as a block or diamond, is filled or drawn as an outline

Arcs are objects like any other: animation links such as Line Color, Blink, Visibility and Orientation work on them, for example to show a gauge sweep or a flow direction.

The **HMI** palette adds three objects: the **Alarm List**, the live list of active alarms at the bottom of every LiquidWeighHMI screen, the **Alarm History**, used on the Alarm History screen, and the **Recipe List** (chapter 11).

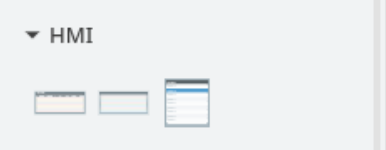


Figure 11. The HMI palette: Alarm List, Alarm History and Recipe List

Note: Keep objects inside the Screen frame, and group repeated symbols (a valve with its tag label) so they can be copied with their links.

To mirror an object, select it and choose **Arrange > Direction > Flip Horizontal** or **Flip Vertical**, or use the **Flip** buttons on the Arrange tab. A group is mirrored as a whole about its center: every object in it, including groups inside it, moves to its mirrored place and is flipped itself, and lines and rotations follow, so a pump symbol that faces right faces left. Text stays readable.

8 Animation links

Animation links make objects live. Select an object and open the **Animation** tab of the Format panel. The top of the tab lists every link type; click one to add it. Links already on the object are marked, and their settings appear below.



Figure 12. The Animation tab for the START button, with its links marked

Table 9. Animation link families

Family	Links	What they do
Touch links	User Input, Pushbutton, Action Script, Show Window, Hide Window, Slider Horizontal and Vertical	Operator actions: enter a value, set or toggle a tag, run a script, open or close a window, drag a slider
Line, Fill and Text Color	Discrete, Analog, Discrete Alarm, Analog Alarm	Color from an on/off value, from value bands, or from a tag's alarm state

Family	Links	What they do
Value / Movement	Location, Width, Height, Percent Fill, Orientation	Move, size, fill or rotate an object in proportion to a value
Miscellaneous	Visibility, Blink, Enable	Show or hide, flash, and allow or block touch
Value Display	Value Display	Show a value or text in place of the object's label

Numbers in links (ranges, limits) are expressions too, so they can come from tags. The sections below walk through the links LiquidWeighHMI uses.

8.1 A valve: status color, fault blink and faceplate

Each valve symbol on the Process screen carries three links. SV-102 is selected in Figure 13.

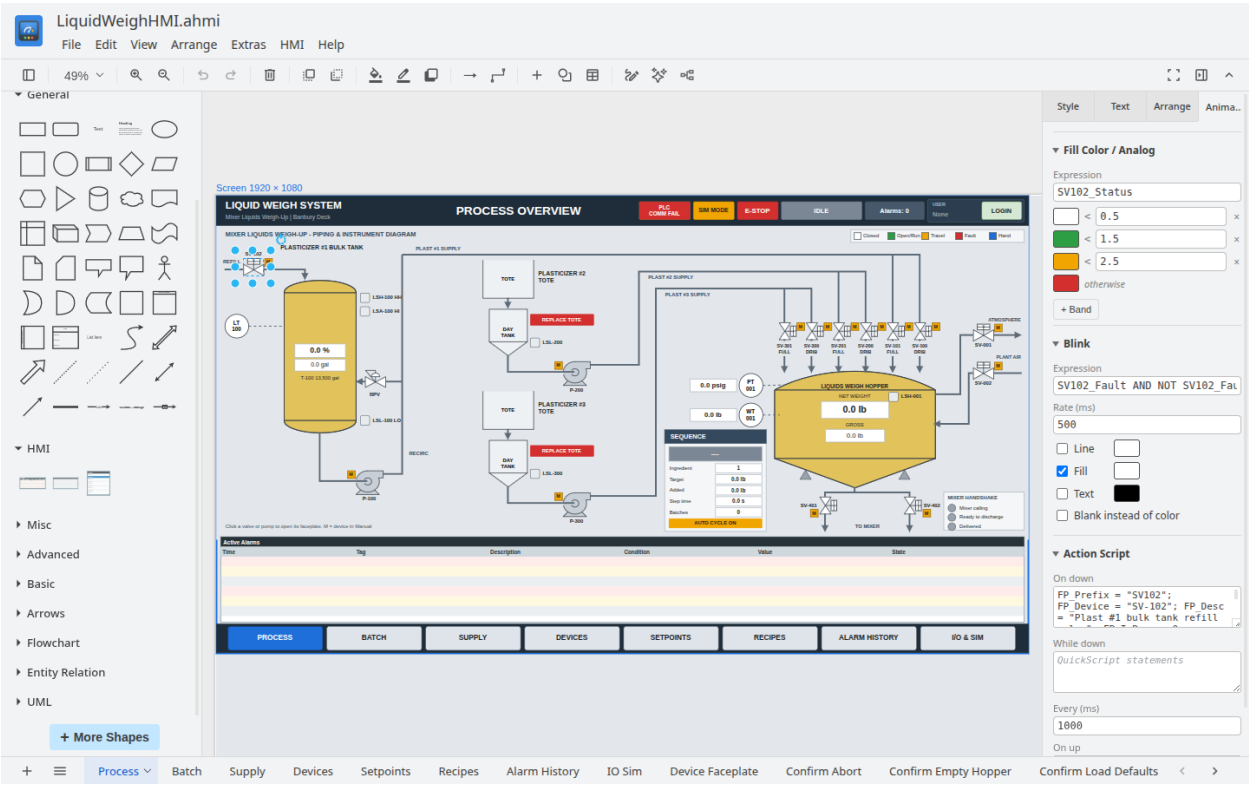


Figure 13. The SV-102 valve and its links

- **Fill Color / Analog** on SV102_Status: below 0.5 (closed) white, below 1.5 (open) green, below 2.5 (travel) amber, otherwise (fault) red. The first band whose limit the value is below wins.
- **Blink** on SV102_Fault AND NOT SV102_FaultAck: flashes the fill while a fault is unacknowledged.
- **Action Script** (On down): FP_Prefix = "SV102"; FP_Device = "SV-102"; ... tells the faceplate which device to show (section 9.4), and ShowWindow("Device Faceplate", 132, 80); opens it beside the valve (section 9.5).

8.2 The weigh hopper: percent fill

The hopper vessel fills with its net weight. **Percent Fill / Vertical** maps WT001 from 0 to 150 lb to 0 to 100 % fill, from the bottom up.

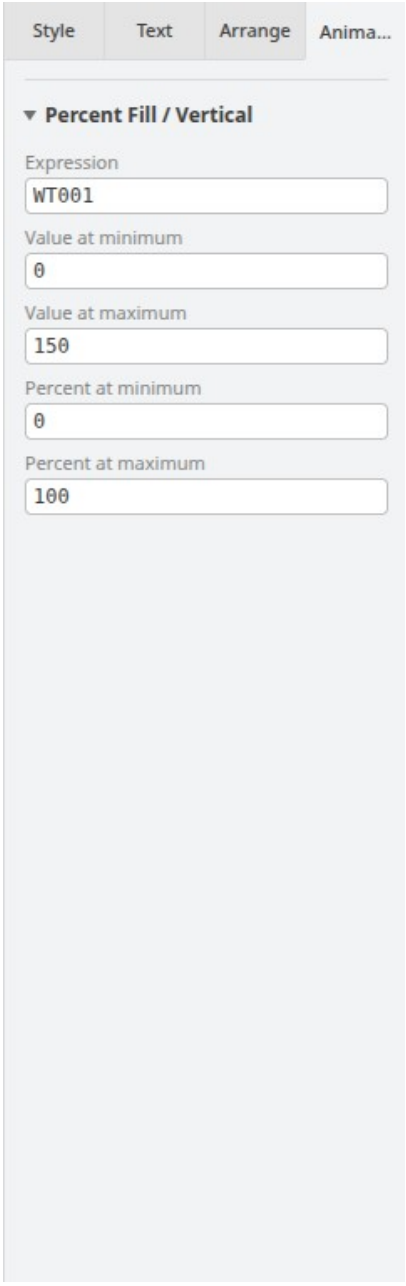


Figure 14. Percent Fill on the weigh hopper

Note: Percent Fill draws only the filled part of the object, outline included. Place an identical shape with no fill on top as the vessel outline, as LiquidWeighHMI does.

8.3 Hopper pressure: value display and alarm colors

The pressure box shows PT001 with one decimal and the suffix psig (**Value Display**), and its fill follows the tag's alarm state (**Fill Color / Analog Alarm**): normal white, High amber, HiHi red. The limits come from the tag in the Tag Dictionary, so they are set in one place.

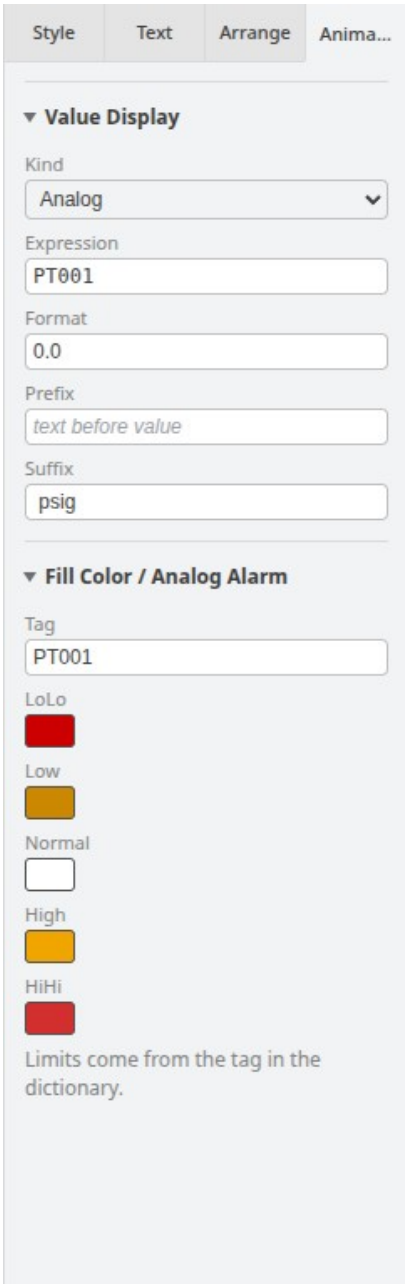


Figure 15. Value Display and Fill Color / Analog Alarm on PT001

8.4 Setpoints: user input

On the Batch screen the operator enters the batch volume by touching its value. **User Input** (analog) on `Rcp_TotalVol` accepts 0 to 12 gallons with the prompt "Total batch volume (gal, max 12)" and shows an on-screen keypad. A **Value Display** on the same object shows the current value.



Figure 16. User Input and Value Display on the batch volume

8.5 Commands: pushbutton and enable

The START button on the Batch screen is a **Pushbutton** that sets PB_Start when touched, allowed only while Seq_Idle AND Seq_StartPerm (Enable when). Its fill and text colors show when it is available. An **Enable** link on _AccessLevel > 0 blocks it until someone is logged in (chapter 10).

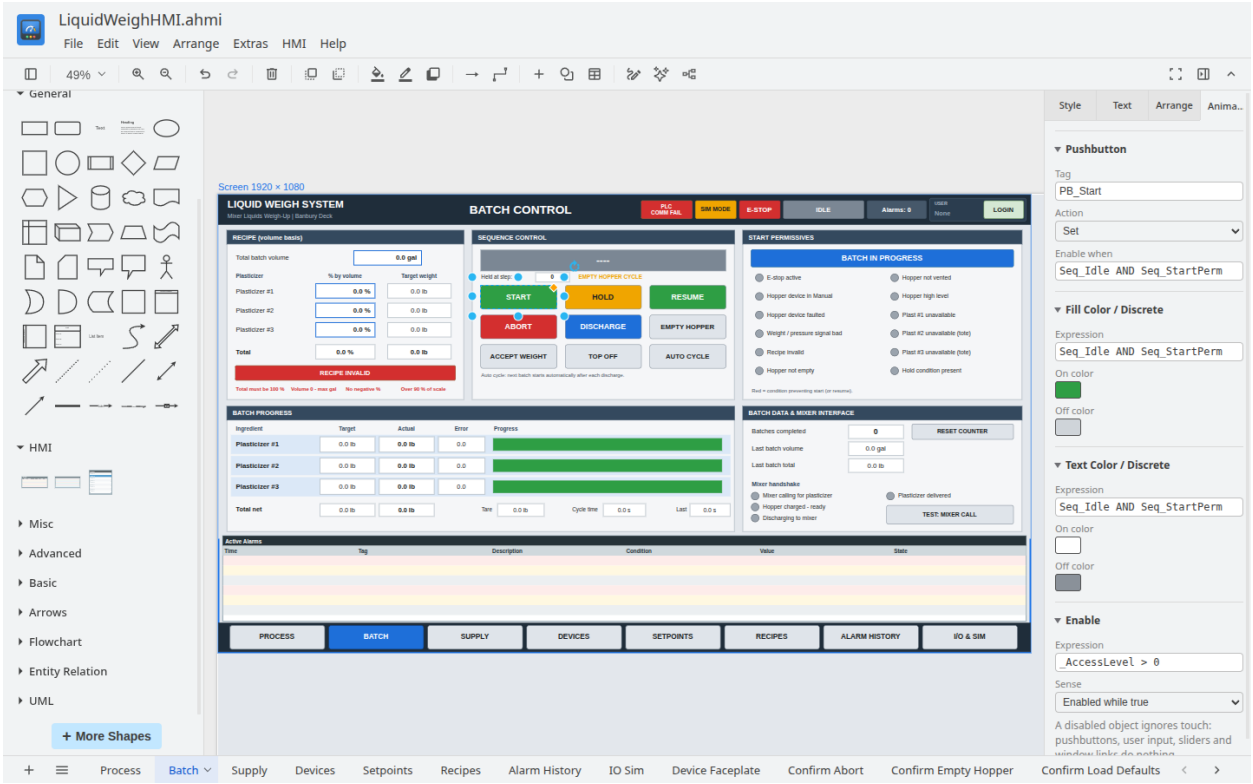


Figure 17. The START button: Pushbutton, colors and Enable

Table 10. Pushbutton actions

Action	Effect
Toggle	Inverts the tag on each touch
Set	Writes 1 (START, HOLD, RESUME in LiquidWeighHMI)
Reset	Writes 0
Direct	1 while pressed, 0 when released (jog buttons)

9 Expressions and scripts

Links use expressions, and scripts (Action Script links and window scripts) use statements, both in the InTouch QuickScript style.

Table 11. Expression syntax

Element	Examples
Tags and dotfields	PT001, SV001_Status, PT001.InAlarm, PT001.Acked, PT001.MaxEU
Operators	+ - * / MOD, == <> < <= > >=, AND OR NOT, parentheses
Literals	12.5, "IDLE"
Functions	Abs(x), Round(x), Text(value, "0.00") and the others in section 9.3
Statements (scripts)	Pump_Run = 1; IF cond THEN ... ELSE ... ENDIF;

Table 12. System tags

Tag	Value
_AlarmsActive	Number of active alarms (the Alarms: n box in LiquidWeighHMI's header)
_AlarmsUnacked	Number of unacknowledged alarms
_AckAll	Write 1 to acknowledge every alarm
_Username	Logged-in user, or None
_AccessLevel	Logged-in user's access level, or 0

9.1 Window scripts

A window can run a script when it opens (**On show**), repeatedly while it is open (**While showing**, every n ms) and when it closes (**On hide**). Every LiquidWeighHMI screen turns the PLC's sequence step number into the text shown in the header, four times a second:

```
IF Seq_Step == 0 THEN StepText = "IDLE"; ENDIF;
IF Seq_Step == 5 THEN StepText = "TARE"; ENDIF;
IF Seq_Step == 11 THEN StepText = "PLAST #1 FAST FILL"; ENDIF;
...
```

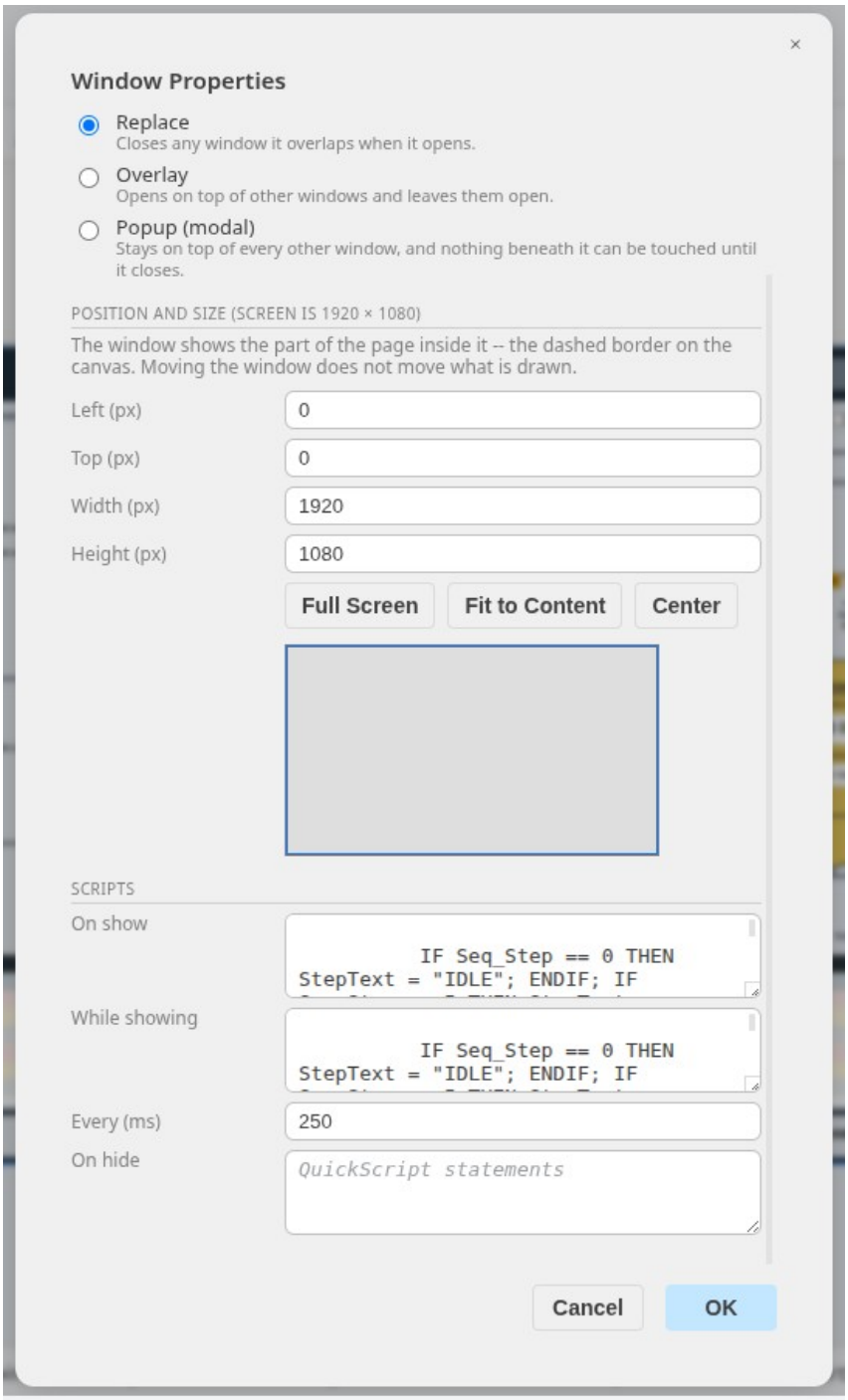


Figure 18. Window scripts of the Process screen (While showing every 250 ms)

9.2 Action scripts

An **Action Script** link runs statements when the object is pressed (On down), repeatedly while held (While down) and when released (On up). The LOGIN button in LiquidWeighHMI's header logs in or out:

```
IF _Username == "None" THEN ShowLogin(); ELSE Logout(); ENDIF;
```



Figure 19. The LOGIN button: Action Script, Value Display and colors

9.3 Function reference

Functions take their arguments in parentheses, separated by commas. Any argument can be a literal (12.5, "Standard Blend"), a tag or a whole expression. Function names are not case-sensitive.

- **Math and text functions** return a value and can be used anywhere: in animation links and in scripts.
- **Security, indirect tag, window, screen and recipe functions** do something (open a window, log in, link or write tags, save a file), so they can be called only from scripts: Action Scripts and window scripts. Validate reports one used in an animation link.
- Functions that succeed or fail return **1** or **0**, so a script can test them: IF Login(LoginName, LoginPassword) THEN ... ENDIF;.

Table 13. Math and text functions (links and scripts)

Function	Arguments	What it does
Abs(x)	x: a number	The absolute value of x. Abs(-3.5) is 3.5
Sqrt(x)	x: a number, 0 or more	The square root of x
Sqr(x)	x: a number	x squared (x × x)
Int(x)	x: a number	x with its fraction dropped. Int(7.9) is 7 and Int(-7.9) is -7
Round(x)	x: a number	x rounded to the nearest whole number; a half rounds up. Round(2.5) is 3
Min(a, b)	a, b: numbers	The smaller of a and b. Min(PT001, 50) is never more than 50
Max(a, b)	a, b: numbers	The larger of a and b
StringLen(text)	text: text	The number of characters in text. StringLen(RecipeName) == 0 is true when no recipe is selected
Text(value, format)	value: a number format: text	The number as text, formatted by a picture such as "0.00". The digits after the point in format give the decimals, and the digits before it the minimum number of whole digits, padded with zeros. Text(3.14159, "0.00") is "3.14" and Text(7, "000") is "007"

Table 14. Security functions (scripts only)

Function	Arguments	What it does
ShowLogin()	None	Opens the login window: user name, masked password and an on-screen keyboard. The window checks the password and logs the user in. Returns 1
Login(name, password)	name, password: text	Logs in when the name and password match a user. Returns 1, or 0 when they do not. For custom login screens

Function	Arguments	What it does
Logout()	None	Logs the current user out: _Username becomes None and _AccessLevel 0. Returns 1
ChangePassword(old, new)	old, new: text	Changes the logged-in user's password from old (the current password) to new (not empty), saved on this computer. Returns 1, or 0 when old is wrong or new is empty
ShowUserManager()	None	Opens the Users window while running, to add, change or remove users on this computer (section 10.2). Returns 1

Table 15. Indirect tag function (scripts only)

Function	Arguments	What it does
LinkIndirectTag(indirect, tag)	indirect, tag: tag names as text	Points the indirect tag at the tag, replacing any earlier link; reading or writing the indirect tag then reads or writes that tag, in every window. The names can be built: LinkIndirectTag("FP_Status", "SV" + Text(Unit, "000") + "_Status"). Returns 1, or 0 with an Indirect Tag Error window when a name is unknown or the types do not match

Table 16. Window function (scripts only)

Function	Arguments	What it does
ShowWindow(name, left, top, modal, wait)	name left, top, modal, wait: optional	Opens the window (page) named by name (text), as a Show Window link does. left and top (screen pixels; "" keeps the window's own) move it for this showing; it still shows the same part of its page. modal (0 or 1) overrides a popup's modality: with 0 the windows beneath can still be touched. With wait 1 the script pauses until the window closes, so it can act on the operator's choice; by default it carries on at once. Like ShowRecipeSelect it must be a statement on its own or the whole right side of an assignment. Returns 1, or 0 with a Window Error window when the name is unknown, a position is not a number or the window would be off the screen

Table 17. Screen function (scripts only)

Function	Arguments	What it does
ScreenToPDF()	None	Saves the screen as the operator sees it, popups included, as a one-page PDF: landscape Letter, the screen fitted, centered and at least 1/4 inch from every edge. A Save window opens with the page's name as the file name (in Append HMI Web, the browser downloads the file). Returns 1 when the Save window opens; the script does not wait for it (section 9.6)

In the recipe functions, `book` is the name of a recipe book defined in **HMI > Recipes** and `name` the name of a recipe in it: text of 1 to 64 characters. Names are not case-sensitive. Chapter 11 shows them at work.

Table 18. Recipe functions (scripts only)

Function	Arguments	What it does
RecipeSave(book, name)	book, name	Saves the current values of the book's Save/Load tags as recipe name, replacing a recipe of that name. Fails if any of the values has bad quality
RecipeLoad(book, name)	book, name	Writes the recipe's values to the book's Save/Load tags
RecipeDownload(book, name)	book, name	Copies each Save/Load tag's value to its Upload/Download tag, usually sending the recipe to the PLC. name is not used: give "" or the selected recipe
RecipeUpload(book, name)	book, name	Copies each Upload/Download tag's value back to its Save/Load tag, usually bringing the PLC's values into the HMI. name is not used
RecipeExport(book, name)	book, name	Writes the recipe to a CSV file that the operator chooses (in Append HMI Web, the browser downloads it). Returns 1 when the file window opens
RecipeImport(book, name)	book, name	Reads a recipe CSV file that the operator chooses and saves it as recipe name. Returns 1 when the file window opens
RecipeDelete(book, name, confirm)	book, name confirm: optional	Deletes the recipe. With confirm 1, a Yes/No window asks the operator first; No returns 0
RecipeRename(book, name, newName)	book, name, newName	Renames the recipe to newName, which must not already be in the book
ShowRecipeSelect(book, x, y, w, h)	book x, y, w, h: optional	Opens a window listing the book's recipes, with up and down arrow buttons, Select and Cancel, and returns the chosen name, or "" for Cancel. The script waits until the operator chooses, so it must be a statement on its own or the whole right side of an assignment: `Pick = ShowRecipeSelect("B");`. x, y, w, h place the window: position and size in screen pixels

The recipe functions other than ShowRecipeSelect return 1 when they succeed and 0 when they fail. A failure also opens the Recipe Error window (section 11.5).

9.4 Indirect tags: one faceplate for every device

LiquidWeighHMI has 11 valves and 3 pumps, and one **Device Faceplate** for all of them. Its objects use **indirect tags** (section 5): FP_Status, FP_Manual, FP_CmdOn and so on, which have no value of their own. When the faceplate opens, a script links each of them to the tag of the device being shown, so FP_Status reads SV102_Status for SV-102 and P100_Status for P-100. A change to the faceplate is made once and applies to every device.

Opening it takes two steps. First, the valve or pump symbol's Action Script names the device in memory tags and opens the faceplate beside the symbol (section 9.5):

```
FP_Prefix = "SV102"; FP_Device = "SV-102";
FP_Desc = "Plast #1 bulk tank refill valve";
FP_IsPump = 0; FP_HasLimits = 1; FP_OperatorOnly = 1;
ShowWindow("Device Faceplate", 132, 80);
```

Then the faceplate's **On show** script builds each tag name from the prefix and links the indirect tags. A pump links the shared command tags to its Start and Stop, a valve to Open and Close:

```
LinkIndirectTag("FP_Status", FP_Prefix + "_Status");
LinkIndirectTag("FP_Manual", FP_Prefix + "_Manual");
...
IF FP_IsPump THEN
   LinkIndirectTag("FP_CmdOn", FP_Prefix + "_CmdStart");
   LinkIndirectTag("FP_CmdOff", FP_Prefix + "_CmdStop");
   LinkIndirectTag("FP_Time", FP_Prefix + "_FailTime");
ELSE
   LinkIndirectTag("FP_CmdOn", FP_Prefix + "_CmdOpen");
   LinkIndirectTag("FP_CmdOff", FP_Prefix + "_CmdClose");
   LinkIndirectTag("FP_Time", FP_Prefix + "_TravelTime");
   IF FP_HasLimits THEN
      LinkIndirectTag("FP_ZSO", FP_Prefix + "_ZSO");
      LinkIndirectTag("FP_ZSC", FP_Prefix + "_ZSC");
   ENDIF;
ENDIF;
```

- **Heading:** Value Displays of FP_Device and FP_Desc.
- **Valve or pump:** visibility links on FP_IsPump choose the symbol and status colors. Texts that differ, such as OPEN or START, are Discrete Value Displays of FP_IsPump.
- **Variants:** FP_HasLimits shows the limit-switch lamps or a note, and FP_OperatorOnly replaces the mode buttons of the refill valve with a note.
- **Status:** a While showing script turns FP_Status into the words shown (FP_StateText).
- **Dotfields:** FP_Status.Name would show SV102_Status; every dotfield describes the linked tag.

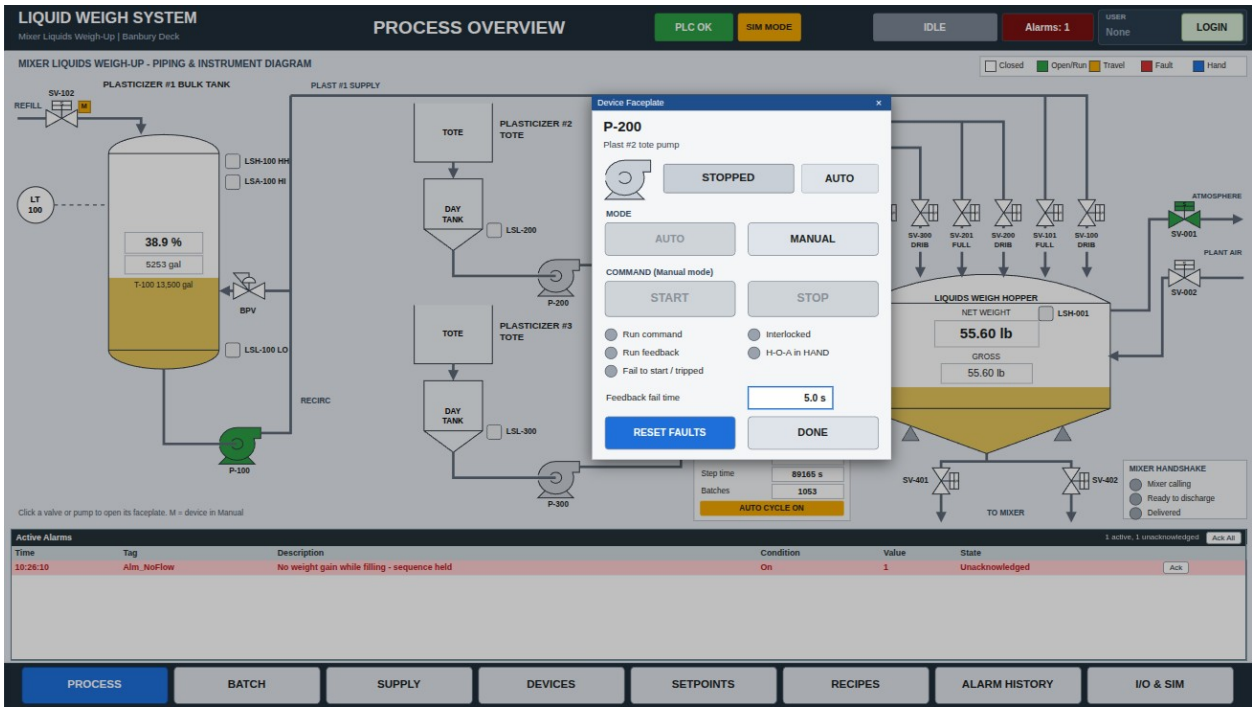


Figure 20. The same faceplate showing pump P-200

Note: Writing to an indirect tag writes the linked tag: the faceplate's MANUAL button sets FP_CmdManual, which is SV100_CmdManual while SV-100 is shown. Before the first link an indirect tag has bad quality and writes to it are ignored.

9.5 Opening windows from scripts: ShowWindow

A Show Window link always opens its window where the window is defined. The ShowWindow function (section 9.3) does the same from a script, and can also move the window, make a popup modal or not, and pause the script until the window closes. LiquidWeighHMI uses it in two ways.

Beside the device touched

Every valve and pump symbol ends its Action Script with a ShowWindow call that places the Device Faceplate beside the symbol, so the operator still sees the device being operated. The faceplate still shows its own part of its page; only its place on the screen changes. P-100, at the bottom left of the Process screen, opens it at 414, 398:

```
FP_Prefix = "P100"; FP_Device = "P-100"; ...
ShowWindow("Device Faceplate", 414, 398);
```

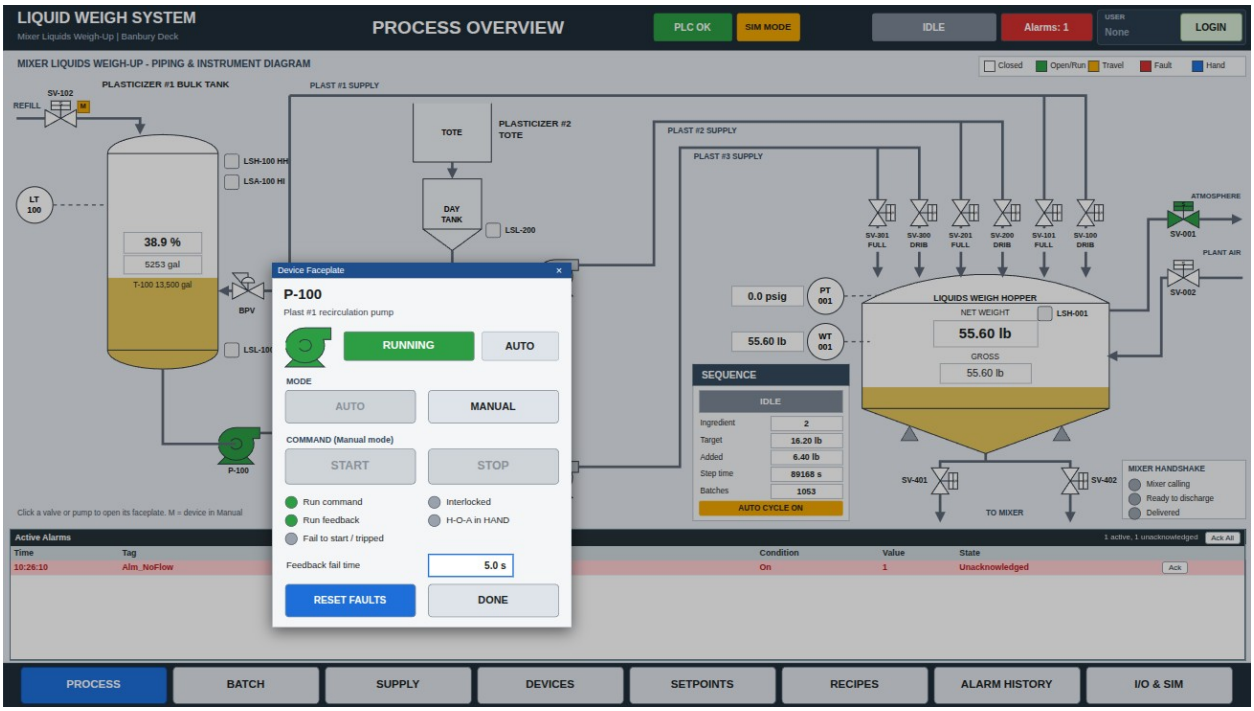


Figure 21. The Device Faceplate opened beside pump P-100

Waiting for an answer

ABORT on the Batch screen asks first. Its Action Script opens the Confirm Abort popup with wait (the fifth argument), so the script pauses at ShowWindow until the popup closes, then acts on the answer:

```
IF Seq_Running OR Seq_Held THEN
   AbortConfirmed = 0;
   ShowWindow("Confirm Abort", "", "", 1, 1);
   IF AbortConfirmed THEN
      PB_Abort = 1;
   ENDIF;
ENDIF;
```

The popup's YES button sets AbortConfirmed = 1 and closes it; NO, or the close box, just closes it. "" keeps the popup where it is defined, and 1 keeps it modal.

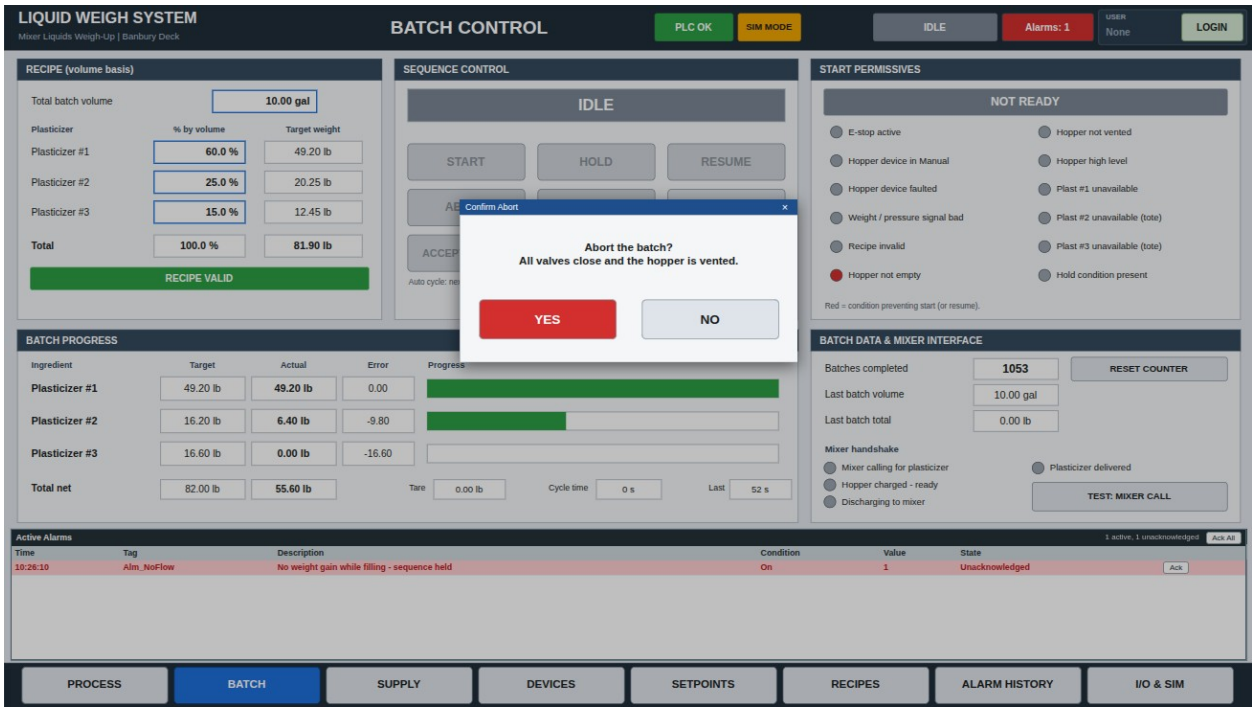


Figure 22. Confirm Abort, opened by ShowWindow with wait: the ABORT script waits for the answer

- While a script waits, the rest of the application runs normally; only that script is paused.
- A waiting ShowWindow must be a statement on its own (or the whole value of an assignment), as here, inside an IF if needed.
- If the window running the script closes, or the application stops, before the answer, the rest of the script does not run.

9.6 Saving the screen as a PDF: ScreenToPDF

ScreenToPDF() keeps a record of a screen: a shift report, a batch at a given moment, or a fault to send to maintenance. Every LiquidWeighHMI screen has a **SAVE PDF** button in its header, whose Action Script is one line:

```
ScreenToPDF();
```

The function saves what the operator sees: the screen with its live values, and any popup or overlay window open on it. The PDF has one landscape Letter page. The screen is fitted to the page as large as it goes, centered, with at least 1/4 inch of margin on every side, and is drawn at the screen's own resolution even when it is shown smaller.

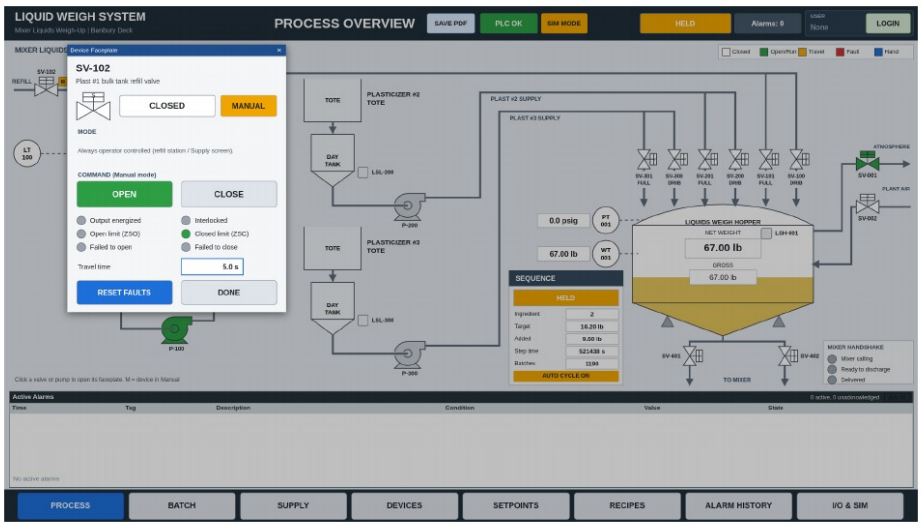


Figure 23. The PDF saved from the Process screen with the Device Faceplate open

- A Save window asks where to save the file. The file name offered is the name of the page shown as the screen, such as Process.pdf. Characters that a file name cannot hold (\ / : * ? " < > |) become _, so a page named "Tank 1/2" is offered as Tank 1_2.pdf.
- Like RecipeExport, the function returns 1 as soon as the Save window opens, and the rest of the script runs at once; it does not wait for the operator. A failure, such as a folder that cannot be written, opens the Screen to PDF Error window. Cancel saves nothing and shows no error.
- In Append HMI Web the browser downloads the file, to its downloads folder or where it asks, depending on the browser's settings.
- Pictures on the screen print when they are embedded in the project, as pictures added in Append HMI Studio are. In the desktop apps, a screen that shows a picture by its web address is captured from the window instead, at the size it is shown.

10 Alarms and security

10.1 Alarms

Alarms come from the limits set on tags (chapter 5). While the application runs, every alarmed tag is watched, whether or not a screen shows it:

- Entering alarm, or escalating (High to HiHi), raises an alarm that needs acknowledging.
- An alarm stays in the Alarm List until it has returned to normal **and** been acknowledged (ISA-18.2).
- The Alarm List object has an **Ack All** button and an **Ack** button on each row. A script can acknowledge with `_AckAll = 1;` or `Tag.Acked = 1;`.
- Every alarm event is written to a daily history file kept for 90 days; the Alarm History object shows it (Figure 41).

10.2 Users and access levels

Open **HMI > Users** to define who can log in. Each user has a name, a password (stored only as a salted hash) and an access level from 0 to 9999.

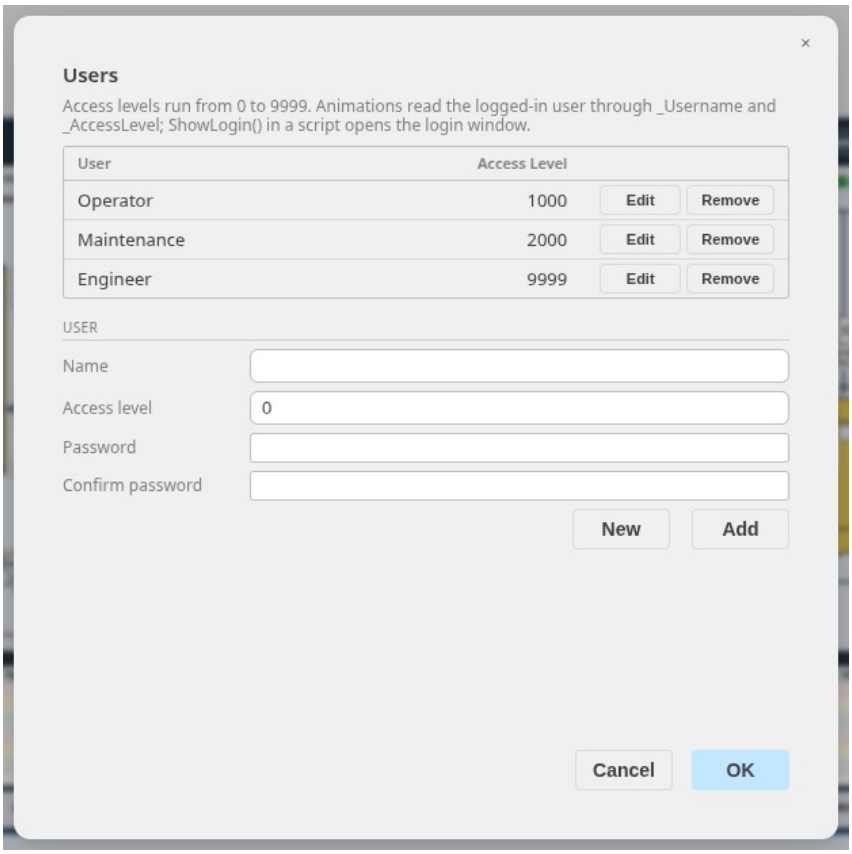


Figure 24. The Users dialog with LiquidWeighHMI's three users

Table 19. LiquidWeighHMI users

User	Access level	Can
Operator	1000	Run batches
Maintenance	2000	Also operate devices in manual

User	Access level	Can
Engineer	9999	Everything, including setpoints and simulation

Screens use _AccessLevel to protect controls: an **Enable** link such as _AccessLevel >= 2000 blocks touch on an object, and a **Visibility** link can hide it. The script function ShowLogin() opens the built-in login window (Figure 25); Login(name, password), Logout(), ChangePassword(old, new) and ShowUserManager() support custom login screens.

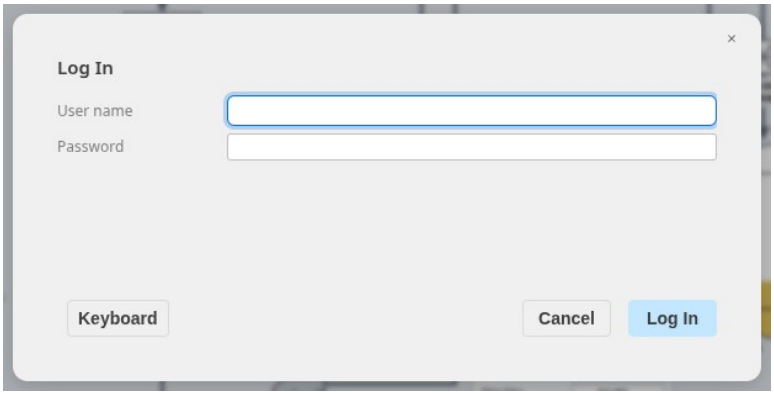


Figure 25. The login window opened by ShowLogin()

11 Recipes

A **recipe** is a named set of tag values that an operator saves and later loads again: the settings of a product, a grade or a batch size. Recipes are kept in **recipe books**. A book lists the tags its recipes hold:

- **Save/Load tags**: the values a recipe stores, usually memory tags that the operator edits on screen. RecipeSave reads them and RecipeLoad writes them.
- **Upload/Download tags** (optional): a second tag paired with each Save/Load tag, usually the PLC tag the value is meant for. RecipeDownload copies the Save/Load values to them and RecipeUpload copies them back.

Keeping the edited values in memory tags means the operator can prepare a recipe without disturbing the PLC, and send it with one Download when the process is ready.

11.1 Recipe books

Open **HMI > Recipes** to define the books. LiquidWeighHMI has one, **Plasticizer Blends**, that holds the Batch screen's recipe: the total batch volume and the share of each of the three plasticizers.

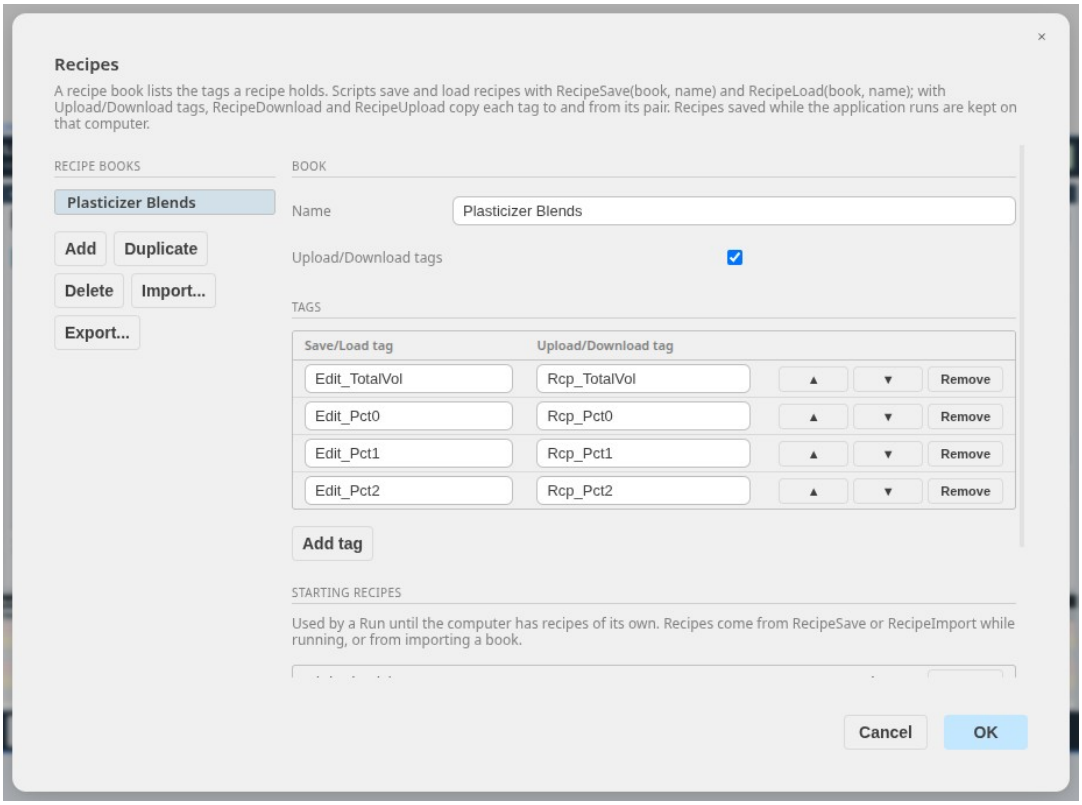


Figure 26. HMI > Recipes: the Plasticizer Blends book and its tags

- **Add**, **Duplicate** and **Delete** manage the books; **Name** renames the selected one.
- **Upload/Download tags** adds the second column of tags.
- **Add tag** adds a row. The arrow buttons reorder the rows and **Remove** deletes one. A tag that is not in the Tag Dictionary is marked.
- **Import…** and **Export…** read and write books, with their starting recipes, as a JSON file, to copy them between projects.
- **OK** checks every book and saves them into the project. Validate also reports books whose tags no longer exist.

Table 20. The tags of the Plasticizer Blends book

Save/Load tag	Upload/Download tag	Holds
Edit_TotalVol	Rcp_TotalVol	Total batch volume, gal (PLC tag Recipe.TotalVol_gal)
Edit_Pct0	Rcp_Pct0	Plasticizer #1, % by volume (Recipe.Pct[0])
Edit_Pct1	Rcp_Pct1	Plasticizer #2, % by volume (Recipe.Pct[1])
Edit_Pct2	Rcp_Pct2	Plasticizer #3, % by volume (Recipe.Pct[2])

The Edit_ tags are retentive memory tags, so the recipe being edited survives a restart. The PLC works out each plasticizer's target weight from the volume, the percentages and the densities on the Setpoints screen.

A book can also carry **starting recipes**: recipes stored in the project, which a computer uses until it saves recipes of its own. LiquidWeighHMI ships with five.

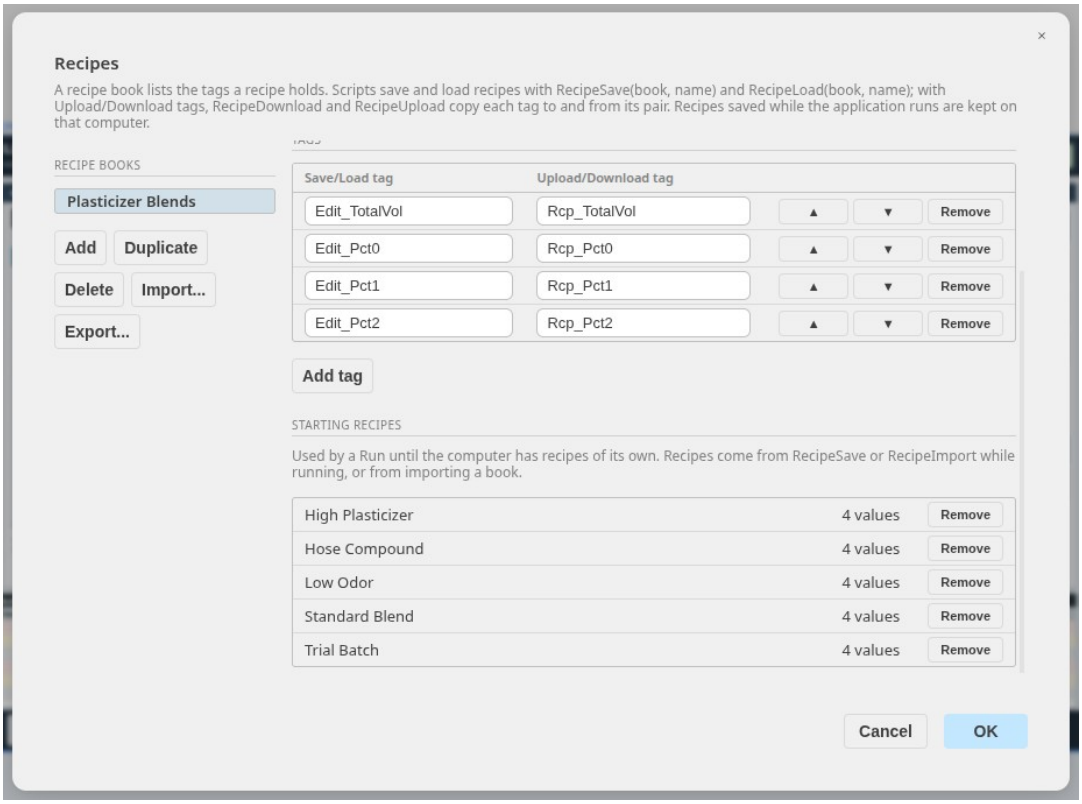


Figure 27. The starting recipes of Plasticizer Blends, below its tags

Table 21. LiquidWeighHMI's starting recipes

Recipe	Volume (gal)	Plasticizer #1 (%)	Plasticizer #2 (%)	Plasticizer #3 (%)
Standard Blend	10	60	25	15
High Plasticizer	10	70	20	10
Hose Compound	9	45	35	20
Low Odor	8	50	50	0
Trial Batch	4	40	30	30

11.2 The Recipes screen

LiquidWeighHMI's **Recipes** screen, on the RECIPES button of the navigation bar, puts the recipe functions to work. It is built only from standard objects, links and scripts, so it can be copied into other applications.

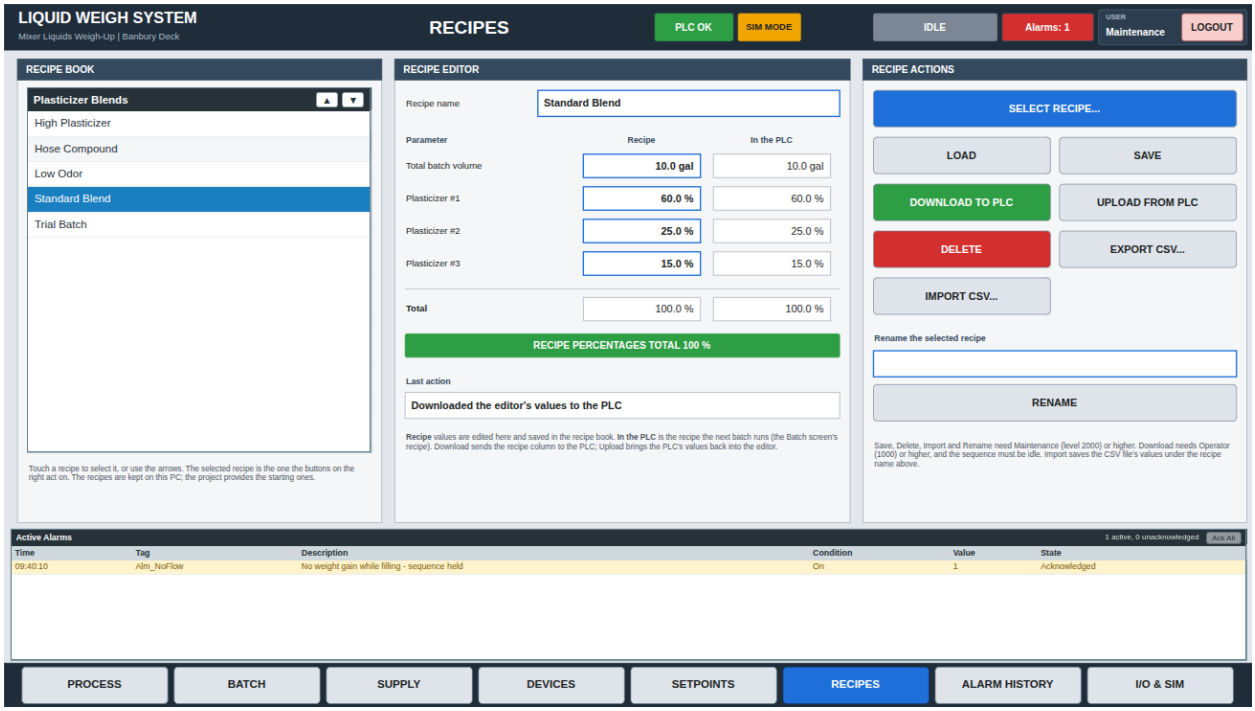


Figure 28. The Recipes screen at Run: Standard Blend selected, loaded and downloaded to the PLC

- **Recipe book** (left): a Recipe List object showing the book's recipes. Touching one, or the arrow buttons in its heading, selects it by writing its name to the message tag RecipeName.
- **Recipe editor** (center): the recipe name, and for each value the editable Save/Load tag (Recipe column) beside its PLC tag (In the PLC column). The total and the green or red banner check that the percentages add up to 100 %. **Last action** shows the result of the last button.
- **Recipe actions** (right): one button for each recipe function, acting on the recipe named in RecipeName.

Table 22. The Recipes screen's buttons

Button	Calls	Allowed for
SELECT RECIPE...	ShowRecipeSelect, then RecipeLoad	Everyone
LOAD	RecipeLoad: the recipe into the editor	Everyone
SAVE	RecipeSave: the editor's values as the recipe	Maintenance and up
DOWNLOAD TO PLC	RecipeDownload: the editor's values to the PLC	Operator and up, sequence idle
UPLOAD FROM PLC	RecipeUpload: the PLC's values into the editor	Everyone

Button	Calls	Allowed for
DELETE	RecipeDelete, asking first	Maintenance and up
EXPORT CSV…	RecipeExport	Everyone
IMPORT CSV…	RecipeImport, saving under the name in the editor	Maintenance and up
RENAME	RecipeRename to the name typed above it	Maintenance and up

Each button is an Action Script. Where access is limited, an **Enable** link (for example _AccessLevel >= 2000) blocks touch, and fill and text color links gray the button out. SAVE reports its result in the Last action box:

```
IF RecipeSave("Plasticizer Blends", RecipeName) THEN
  RecipeMsg = "Saved " + RecipeName;
ENDIF;
```

DOWNLOAD TO PLC is enabled by _AccessLevel >= 1000 AND Seq_Step == 0, so a recipe cannot change while a batch runs. DELETE passes 1 as the third argument, so the operator confirms first:

```
IF RecipeDelete("Plasticizer Blends", RecipeName, 1) THEN
  RecipeMsg = "Deleted " + RecipeName;
  RecipeName = "";
ENDIF;
```

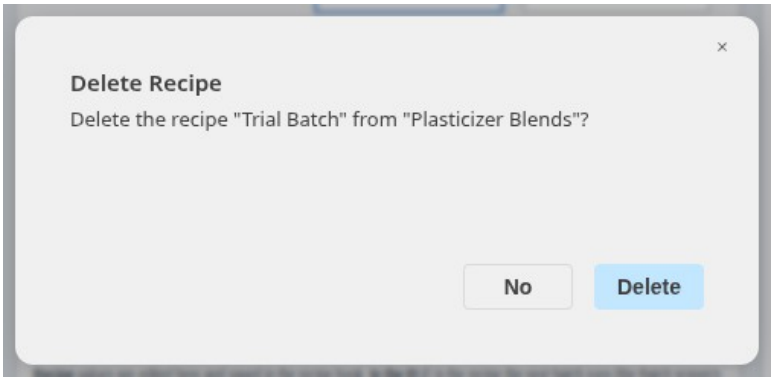


Figure 29. RecipeDelete with confirm: the operator answers before anything is deleted

11.3 The Recipe List object

Recipe List, in the HMI palette, shows a book's recipes while the application runs. Select it and open the Animation tab to set it up:

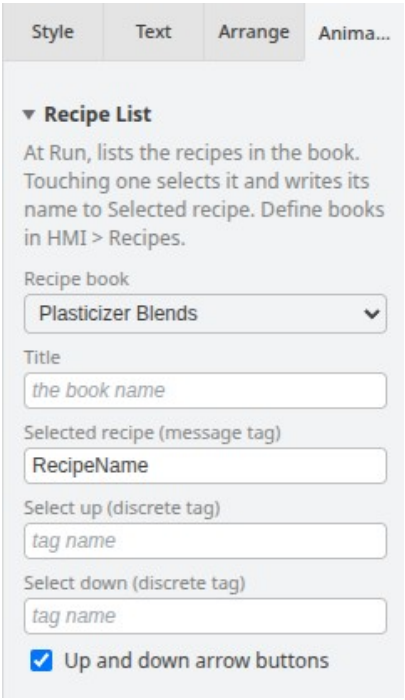


Figure 30. The Recipe List settings of the Recipes screen's list

Table 23. Recipe List settings

Setting	Meaning
Recipe book	The book listed
Title	The heading; empty shows the book's name
Selected recipe	A message tag. The highlighted row follows its value, and touching a row writes the row's name to it
Select up, Select down	Discrete tags. Each change from 0 to 1 moves the selection up or down, for selection from PLC pushbuttons. With nothing selected, down selects the first recipe and up the last
Up and down arrow buttons	Draws arrow buttons in the heading that move the selection the same way

The list is sorted by name and updates as soon as a recipe is saved, renamed or deleted.

11.4 Selecting a recipe in a window

ShowRecipeSelect opens a window listing a book's recipes, for screens without a Recipe List or for a popup choice. The operator touches a recipe, or uses the arrow buttons, then **Select**; the function returns the chosen name, or "" for **Cancel**. LiquidWeighHMI's SELECT RECIPE... button loads the chosen recipe into the editor:

```
RecipePick = ShowRecipeSelect("Plasticizer Blends");
IF RecipePick <> "" THEN
   RecipeName = RecipePick;
   RecipeLoad("Plasticizer Blends", RecipeName);
   RecipeMsg = "Loaded " + RecipeName + " into the editor";
ENDIF;
```

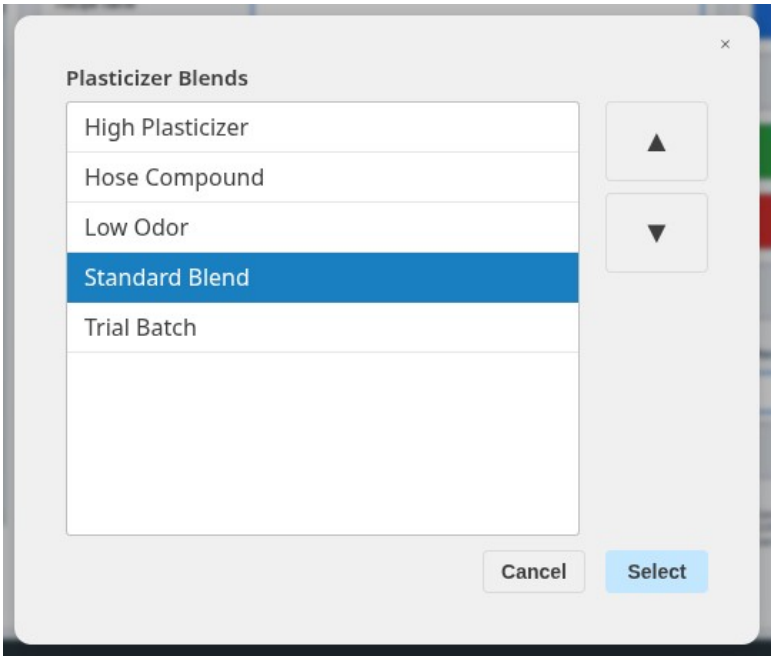


Figure 31. The window opened by ShowRecipeSelect

- The script waits at ShowRecipeSelect until the operator chooses, then continues with the result. It must therefore be a statement on its own or the whole right side of an assignment, as above; Validate reports it inside an IF condition or an expression.
- The window is centered. ShowRecipeSelect(book, x, y, w, h) places it instead, at x, y with width w and height h in screen pixels, scaled with the screen.
- Assigning the result to a separate tag, as above, keeps the current selection when the operator cancels.

11.5 When a recipe function fails

A recipe function that cannot do its job returns 0 and shows the **Recipe Error** window. The window names the call with its arguments and gives the reason, such as an empty recipe name, a recipe that does not exist, or PLC values with bad quality because the controller is not connected. Pressing SAVE with no recipe name gives:



Figure 32. The Recipe Error window

- The window opens after the script finishes, so the rest of the script still runs.
- Further failures before **OK** is pressed join the same window (up to 10, then "and n more"); a failure repeated by a While showing script is counted rather than repeated.
- The operator's own choices are not errors: Cancel in the select window, No when deleting and cancelling a file window return 0 or "" without one.
- Every failure is also written to the runtime log.

11.6 Where recipes are kept

The project holds the books and their starting recipes. Recipes saved while running (RecipeSave, RecipeRename, RecipeDelete, RecipeImport) are kept on the computer running the application, book by book: once a computer saves a recipe in a book, its own list replaces that book's starting recipes there.

Table 24. Where saved recipes are kept

Running in	File
Append HMI Studio (Run)	recipes\<project>.json in the Studio's settings folder
A published application	%APPDATA%\<Product>\recipes\<Product>.json
Append HMI Desktop, Append HMI Web	recipes\<application>.json in their settings folder

- **HMI > Clear Runtime Recipes** (with the Run stopped) forgets the recipes the Studio saved, so Run starts again from the starting recipes.

- In Append HMI Web all browsers share the server's recipes; one saved in one browser appears in the others within a few seconds.
- A recipe CSV file has a #Recipe,<book>,<name> line, then Tag,Value and one line per tag. Importing takes only the book's Save/Load tags and reports any others.

12 Testing

12.1 Validate

HMI > Validate Expressions checks every link, script and PLC address and lists any problem with the page and object; click a problem to go to it. Validate before every Run and Publish.

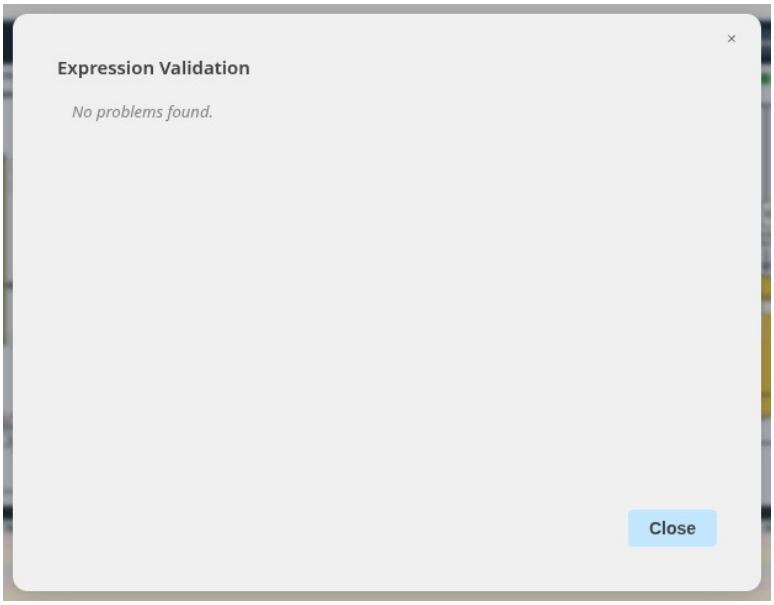


Figure 33. Validation of LiquidWeighHMI: no problems found

12.2 Run

HMI > Run (F5) runs the application inside the Studio: the drawing is locked, the start-up windows open, and the application connects to its PLCs. A green RUNNING banner shows that the screen is live and that touching it operates real equipment. **HMI > Stop** returns to editing.

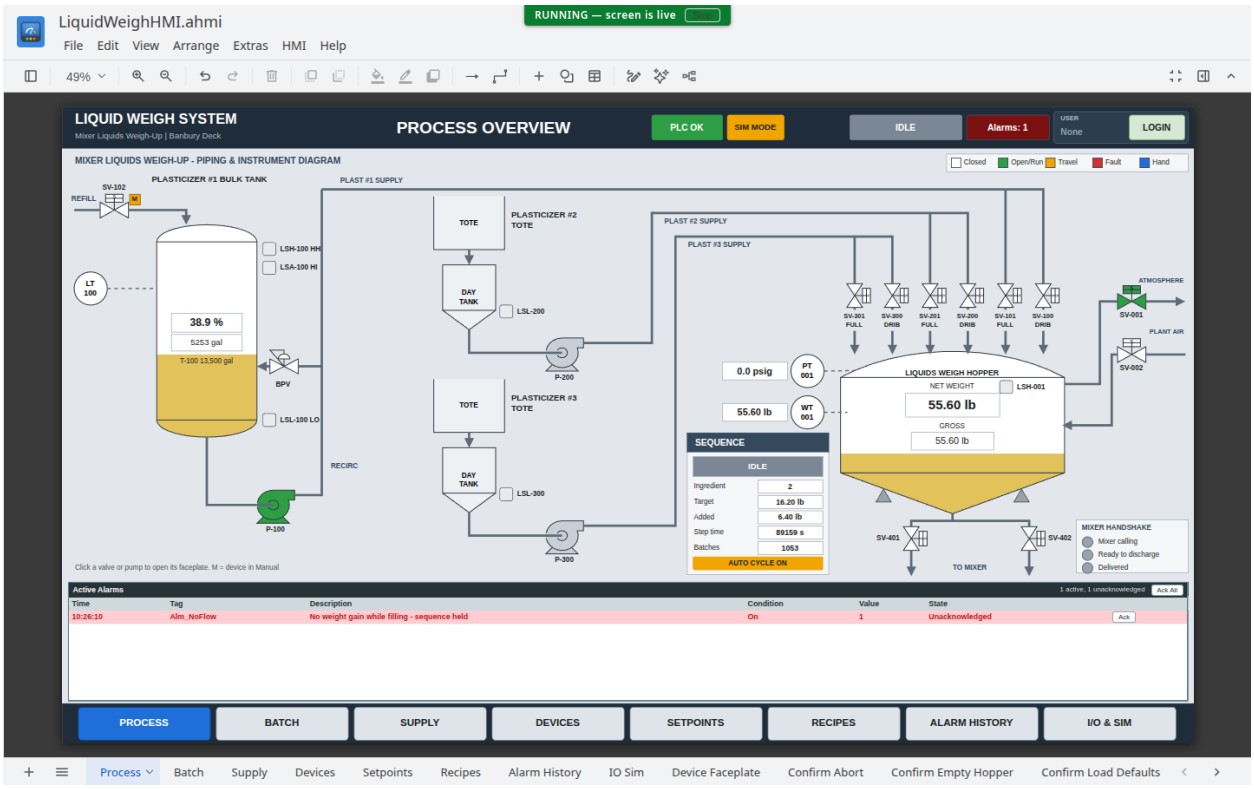


Figure 34. LiquidWeighHMI running in the Studio

The screens below were captured while LiquidWeighHMI ran against its controller, between batches.

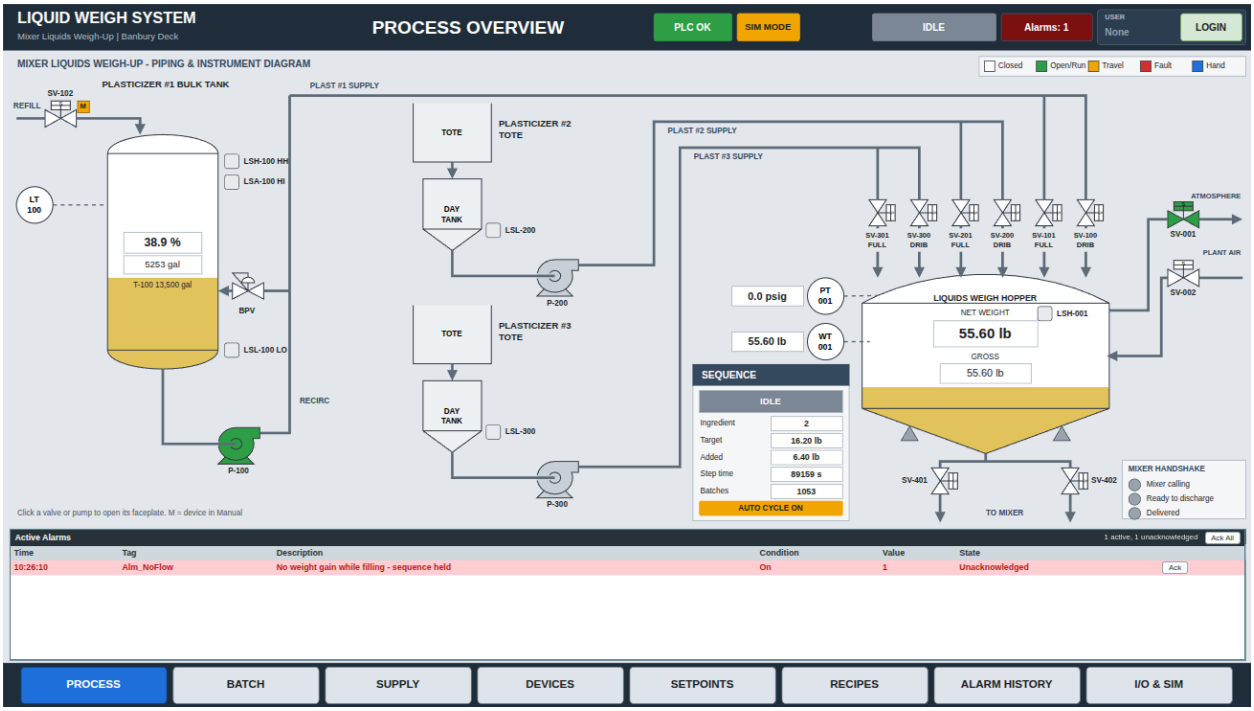


Figure 35. Process screen: tank and hopper levels, valve states, sequence and active alarms

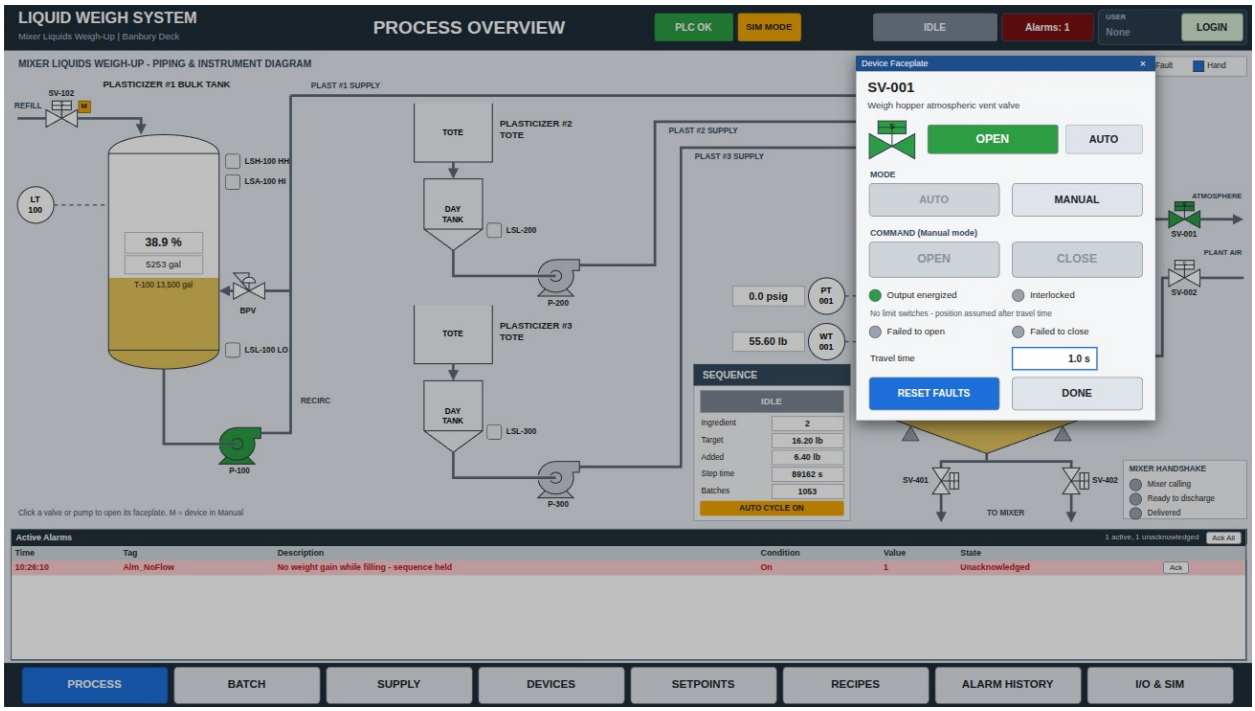


Figure 36. The Device Faceplate showing SV-001: mode, commands, interlocks and fault reset

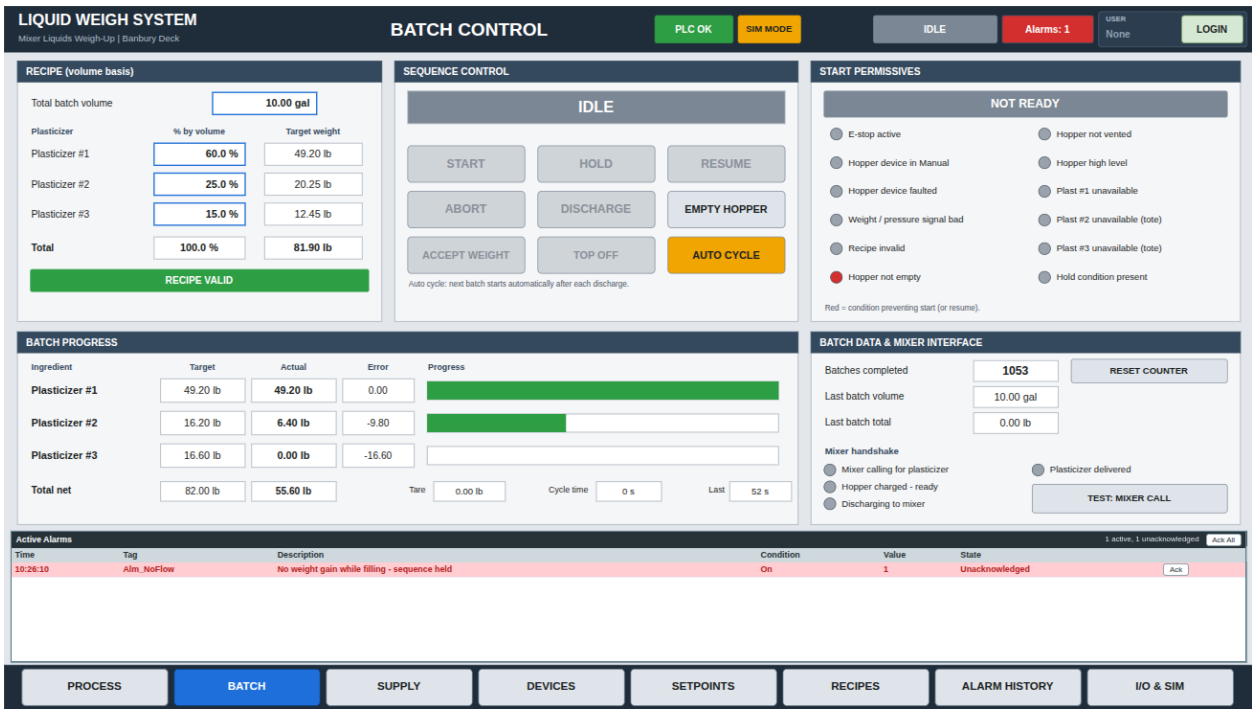


Figure 37. Batch screen: recipe, sequence control, start permissives and batch progress

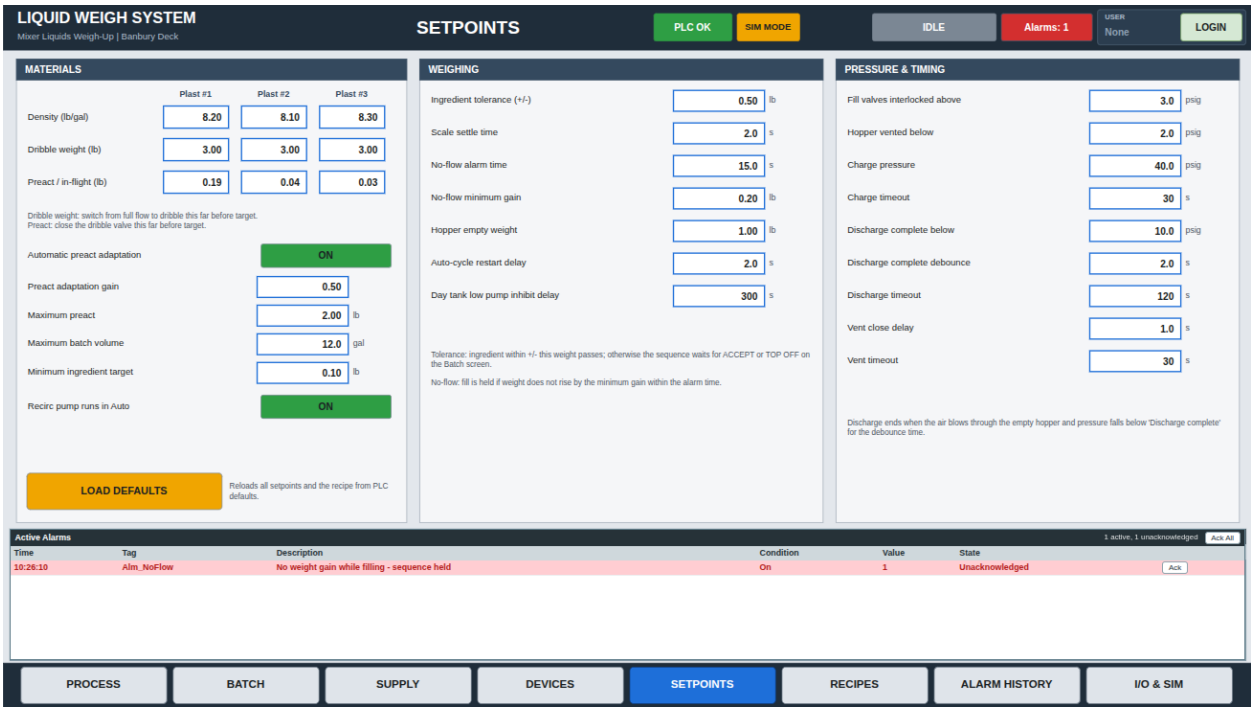


Figure 38. Setpoints screen: materials, weighing, pressure and timing

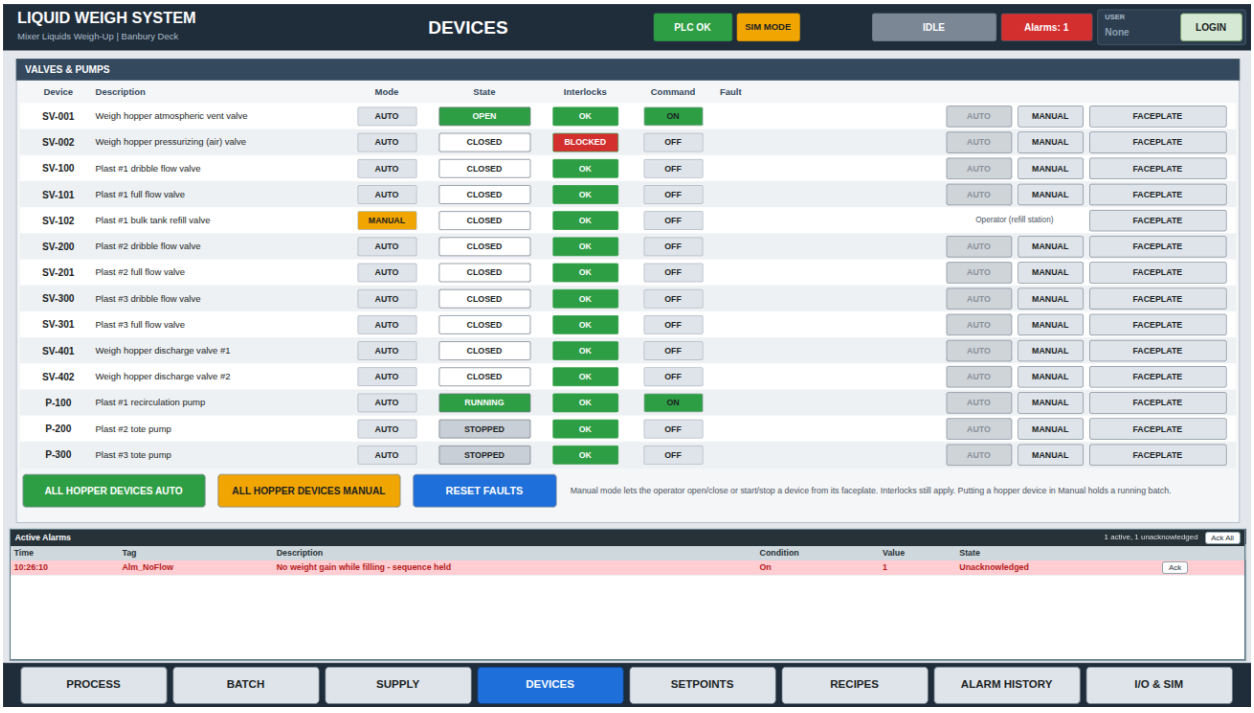


Figure 39. Devices screen: every valve and pump with mode, state and faceplate

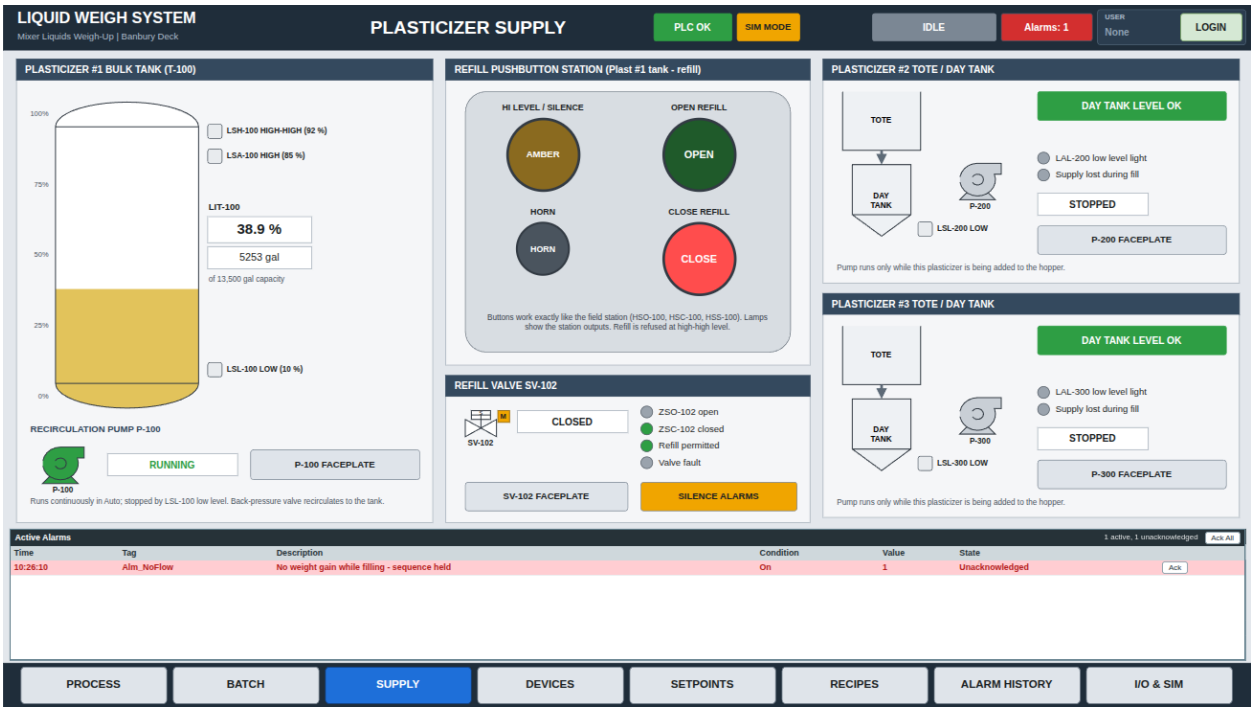


Figure 40. Supply screen: plasticizer tank, refill station and totes

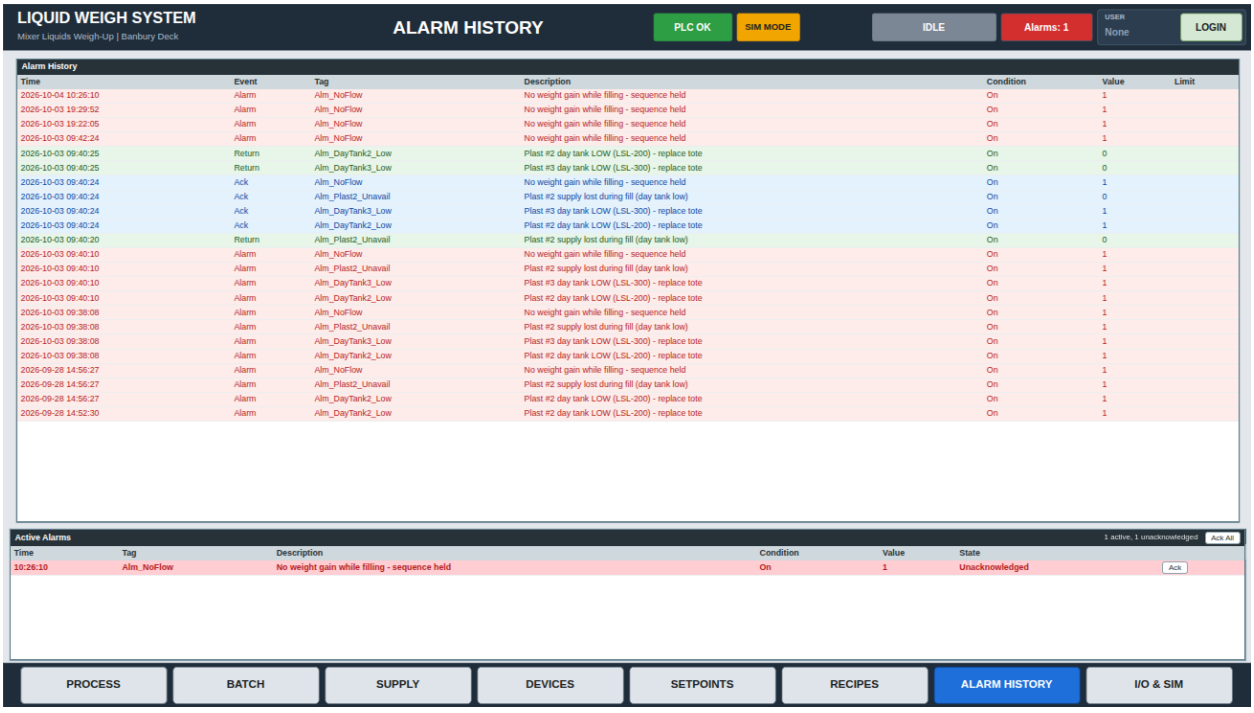


Figure 41. Alarm History screen

Note: HMI > Runtime Log lists connections, device errors, writes and script errors from the run.

13 Deploying

An application can reach the plant floor in three ways.

Table 25. Deployment options

Option	What the target gets	Best for
HMI > Publish	A Windows installer of this one application, with its own name and icon, starting straight into it	A dedicated, locked-down operator station
Append HMI Desktop	One runner installed once; runs any .ahmi file, from shortcuts or at log-in	Stations whose projects change often; Linux
Append HMI Web	A web server; operators open the application in any browser	Viewing and operating from tablets, laptops and control-room PCs

13.1 Publish

HMI > Publish builds a Windows installer from the open project. Give the product name, version and publisher, choose an icon, whether it installs for all users, and whether it adds a desktop shortcut or starts with Windows. Run the Setup.exe on the target PC; the application then starts full screen as set in Application Settings.

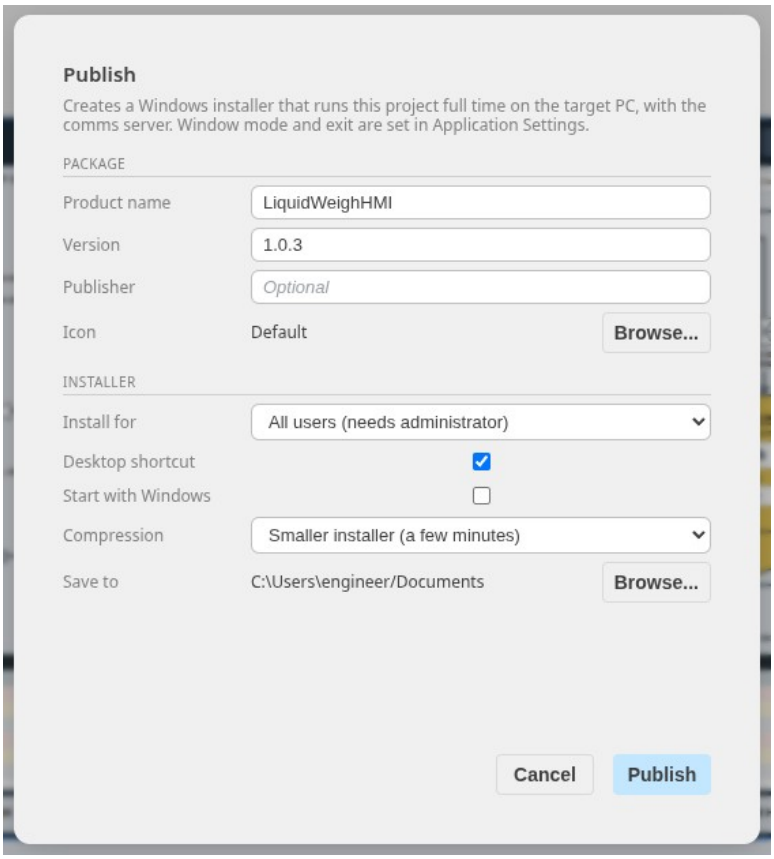


Figure 42. The Publish dialog

13.2 Append HMI Desktop

Append HMI Desktop runs .ahmi files without the editor. Choose an application, then **Run now**, create a desktop shortcut or menu entry, or tick **Run this application automatically when I log in**. From the command line: `append-hmi-desktop LiquidWeighHMI.ahmi`.

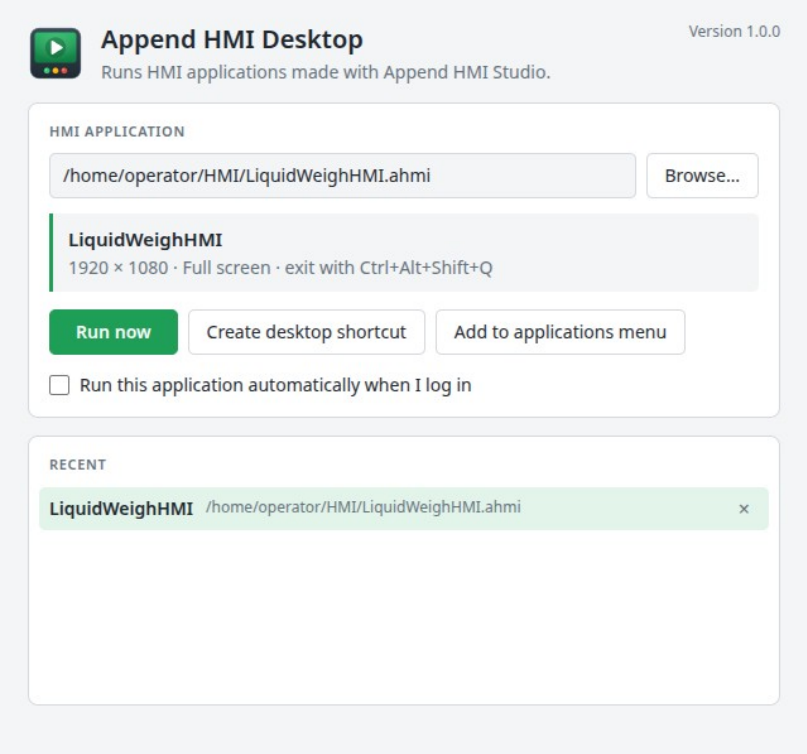


Figure 43. The Append HMI Desktop launcher with LiquidWeighHMI selected

13.3 Append HMI Web

Append HMI Web serves an application to web browsers on the plant network. Choose the application and a port (8480 by default), then **Start web server**; the launcher shows the link to share, with a **Copy** button. If the port is already in use on the PC (by another web server, or another application being served), choose another. In the browser, the view button in the corner fits the screen to the window, maximizes it, or shows it at its original size with scroll bars.

The **Running** list shows every Append HMI Web server on the PC, including ones started in the background from the command line (`--headless`). Each has **Restart**, which starts it again with the same settings and reads the project file afresh (do this after saving changes in Studio; browsers reload by themselves), and **Stop**.

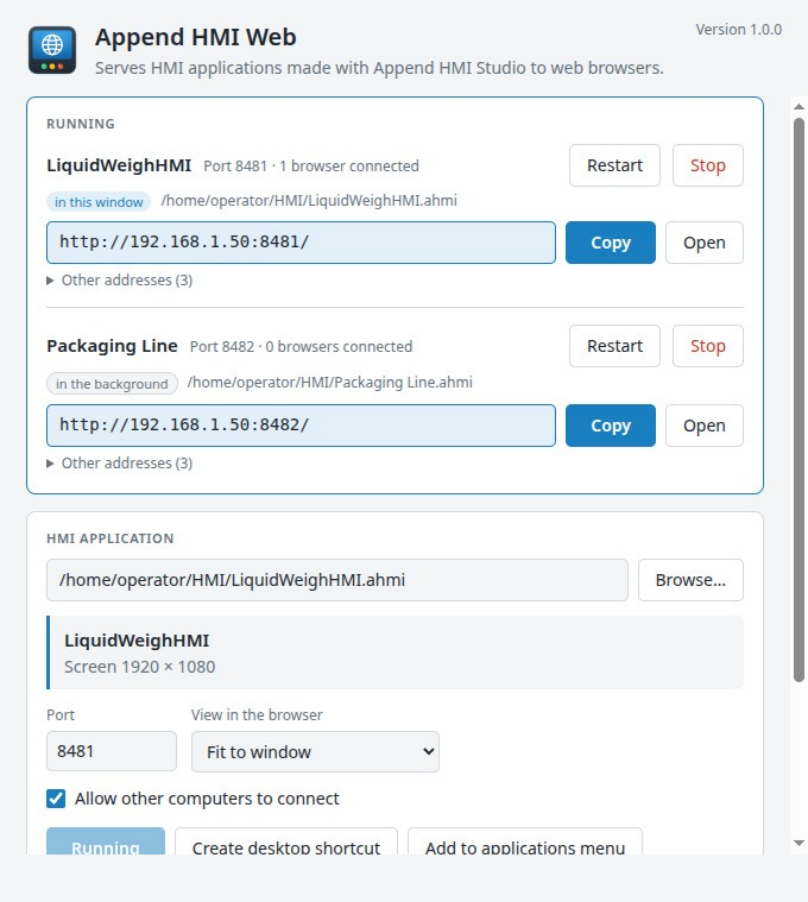


Figure 44. The Append HMI Web launcher: LiquidWeighHMI served on port 8481 to one browser, and a second application running in the background

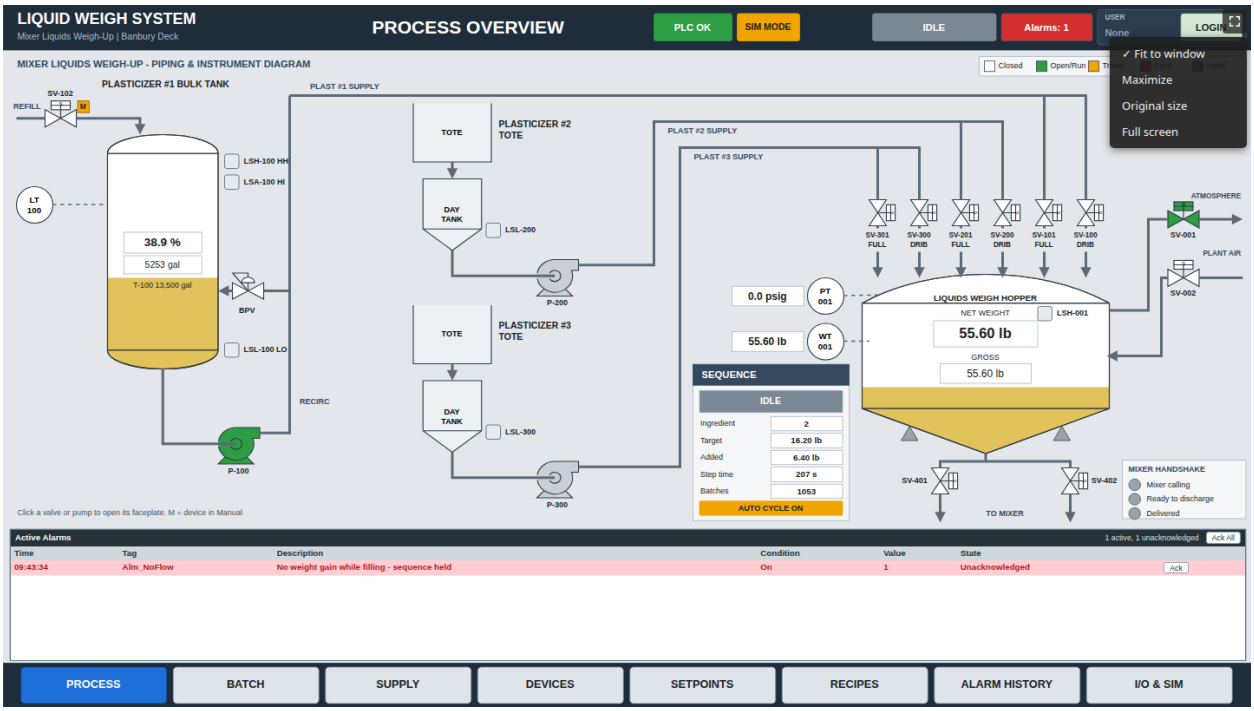


Figure 45. LiquidWeighHMI in a web browser, with the view menu open

14 Tips and troubleshooting

Table 26. Common problems

Symptom	Cause and remedy
Values show ####	The tag has bad quality: the PLC is not connected or the address is wrong. Check HMI > Runtime Log and Test Connection in HMI > Devices
PLC COMM FAIL in the header	The device is unreachable. Check the IP address, slot and network
A button does nothing	An Enable or Pushbutton "Enable when" condition is false, or nobody with the access level is logged in
Validate reports an expression error	Expressions take no ";" (only script statements do); tag names must exist in the Tag Dictionary
A popup opens in the wrong place	Its objects must be drawn at the window's position on its page (Window Properties > Left, Top)
Retentive values are not what you expect	Use HMI > Clear Retentive Values to start from the initial values again
A recipe button does nothing	Its Enable condition is false (access level, or the sequence is running), or the function failed: the Recipe Error window and HMI > Runtime Log give the reason
Run shows old recipes	Recipes saved on this computer replace the starting ones. Use HMI > Clear Runtime Recipes to start from the project's recipes again

Build a symbol once, with its links, group it, and copy it: links travel with the copy. The Animation tab can also copy links from one object and paste them onto others.

Appendix A Command-line automation

Append HMI Studio can build, check, render and publish applications without its window, for scripting and for AI agents:

Table 27. Command-line modes

Command	Does
--hmi-build spec.json -o app.ahmi	Builds a project from a JSON description
--hmi-check app.ahmi	Validates it (exit code 2 when problems are found)
--hmi-render app.ahmi -o folder	Renders every page to PNG
--hmi-dump app.ahmi -o spec.json	Writes a project back out as JSON
--hmi-publish app.ahmi --product "Name" --app-version 1.0.0 -o folder	Builds the Windows installer

The JSON format is documented in doc/HMI_AUTOMATION.md in the Append HMI Studio repository.